



SHIP SECURED

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VB-G RAM G rolled out from A.P. village

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INSIDE

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Russian missile and drone blitz kills 21 in Kyiv

KYIV Russia hammered Kyiv in an 11-hour drone and missile attack overnight into Thursday morning, killing at least 21 civilians in the city and injuring more than 90 others in what Moscow said was retaliation for Ukrainian strikes on Russian oil facilities. » **PAGE 14**



Kuki village in Manipur torched by armed group

GUWAHATI Manipur's trail of violence widened after an armed group attacked and torched a Kuki village in Noney district around 5 a.m. on Thursday. The Kuki Inpi alleged that suspected members of the National Socialist Council of Nagalim carried out the “unprovoked” attack on Leikot. » **PAGE 4**

PF Rules notified; ‘no word yet on hike in pension’

NEW DELHI The Centre published the Rules for the Employees Provident Fund Scheme, the Employees' Pension Scheme, and the Employees' Deposit Linked Insurance Scheme, replacing the old Rules of 1952. Trade unions said the notification does not reflect demands of subscribers such as increase in minimum pension and clarity in providing higher pension for applicants » **PAGE 6**

Falling boulder kills 7 at quarry near Bengaluru

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Seven workers, six of them migrants, were killed and five injured after a massive boulder collapsed on them at a stone quarry in Hulenahalli village in Tavarekere Hobli on the outskirts of Bengaluru, Karnataka, on Thursday morning.

Several workers were engaged in stone-cutting and quarrying activities as a huge mass detached from the rock face in an adjacent quarry and came crashing down on them from a height of about 40 feet.

The boulder collapsed on some vehicles, including a tractor trolley which was loading crushed stones, and left several workers trapped. The accident occurred at around 7:30 a.m.

Seven labourers – five



Hot as ever: Visitors take shelter under an umbrella on a sunny day at Veli beach in Thiruvananthapuram on Thursday, as the forecast predicts a monsoon deficit for the month of July. NIRMALI HARINDRAN



Battered remains: The aftermath of the boulder collapse at the stone quarry site, near Bengaluru on Thursday. K. MURALI KUMAR

from Madhya Pradesh, and one each from Karnataka and Chhattisgarh – were killed on the spot.

Case registered
The five injured were rushed to a hospital for treatment as the Tavarekere police and fire and emergency services carried out rescue operations. The police registered a

the rock mass, which then broke free and rolled down on to the workers at the neighbouring S.R. Udayashankar quarry.

The accused have been identified as D. Anandaswamy, Udayashankar, Pandu, Tirupathi, and others responsible for quarry operations at the Basaveshwara and S.R. Udayashankar stone quarries. According to the FIR, the quarries, which lie adjacent to each other, had been operating in Survey No. 29 for nearly five years.

The FIR said that the accused knowingly allowed quarrying work to continue in an unsafe environment without taking adequate precautionary measures, resulting in the deaths and injuries.

Police said the quarry management had allegedly continued operations despite being aware of the risk



Boosting ties: Prime Minister Narendra Modi with his Japanese counterpart Sanae Takaichi in New Delhi. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Mr. Modi and Ms. Takaichi attended an economic session in which Indian and Japanese companies sealed 129 memoranda of understanding on technology, investment, and artificial intelligence.

According to a document shared by the External Affairs Ministry, Japan is on track to invest \$1 trillion across States, including Haryana, Odisha, Maharashtra, Gujarat, and those in the northeastern region.

Ms. Takaichi highlighted

Free Indo-Pacific priority for India, Japan: PM

Both countries are ‘perfectly aligned’, Japanese PM says and stresses on ‘strategic cooperation’

Countries seal at least 129 MoUs on technology, investment and AI; Japan may invest \$1 trillion

Modi praises deal over defence tech for maritime security; Takaichi expresses concern over Gulf

Saurabh Trivedi
Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

A “free and rules-based Indo-Pacific” is a common priority for India and Japan, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Thursday while welcoming his Japanese counterpart, Sanae Takaichi. Mr. Modi said India and Japan would jointly develop technologies that would help in maintaining maritime security and “regional peace”.

“India and Japan are among the biggest economies of the world. A free, prosperous and rules-based Indo-Pacific is our shared priority. We will jointly pave the way for peace, stability and progress for the entire region,” Mr. Modi said.

“In the field of defence, India and Japan have done the first agreement for co-development of projects. This agreement on naval radio antenna will open a new chapter of defence technology partnership. Now, we will jointly develop such technologies that will help in maintaining regional peace, maritime security, and strengthen rules-based order,” Mr. Modi added.

Maritime security
Ms. Takaichi, who arrived in New Delhi on July 1 for her first visit to India as Prime Minister, renewed her call for an updated free and open Indo-Pacific (FOIP) and emphasised the need for “strategic cooperation”. She said that the two countries were “perfectly aligned”.

the importance of maritime security as the key to maintaining regional stability in the Indo-Pacific.

“Expansion of maritime security is especially important for regional peace and stability,” Ms. Takaichi said, highlighting the har-

Modi, Takaichi unveil Maruti Suzuki plant

NEW DELHI
At the India-Japan Joint Economic Forum on Thursday, Narendra Modi and Sanae Takaichi inaugurated Maruti Suzuki's fourth vehicle manufacturing facility at Kharkhoda in Haryana. This plant will be one of the largest, Suzuki Motors head Toshihiro Suzuki said. » **PAGE 12**

mony between Japan's call for FOIP and the Government of India's emphasis on ocean as a “shared space” that can sustain economic growth and safeguard sovereignty.

“In the midst of international affairs in disarray, the establishment of such an inter-complementary cooperative relationship has become ever more important,” she stated.

She expressed concern about the situation in the Gulf region, where at least 31 Japanese vessels remain stranded near the Strait of Hormuz.

Defence cooperation
The two sides also announced deepening of bilateral defence cooperation through joint military exercises, particularly naval exercises in the Indian Ocean and expanding Maritime Domain Awareness.

Interacting with the media on Thursday evening, Japanese officials said that bilateral cooperation in defence equipment and technology was progressing through industry agreements. They emphasised that the defence technologies being exported were intended for “defence purposes and not for warfare”.

The two sides highlighted the need to collaborate in addressing energy security needs against the backdrop of the disruption in the Persian Gulf region and supported the idea of “strategic stockpiling of crude oil” to serve bilateral requirements. Japan is diversifying energy suppliers in the backdrop of the crisis in West Asia, said Japanese officials.

SC quashes NCLT order for using AI-generated case law

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Observing that the use of non-existent or AI-generated hallucinated judicial precedents is “catastrophic” to the judicial process, the Supreme Court on Thursday set aside an order of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) after finding that it had relied on fictitious AI-generated case laws.

A Bench comprising Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe underscored that courts must adopt a “zero-tolerance” approach towards the reliance on AI-generated precedents without independent verification as it “contaminates” the very “lifeblood of judicial determination”.

“Even if an iota of fake or hallucinated material enters the decision-making process, it would violate the sanctity of adjudication. It is absolutely necessary to maintain integrity in decision-making, and we reiterate and declare zero tolerance for the Bar as well as the Bench to cite, refer to, or rely on such material,” the Bench said.

Cautioning against AI-generated hallucinations quietly permeating legal practice, it warned that reliance on fictitious precedents “subverts the rule of law”.

‘Frame norms’
While acknowledging that “increased workloads of modern life” have compelled lawyers and judges to adapt to AI to improve efficiency, it underlined that meaningful human oversight must remain integral to every stage of the adjudicatory process.

“For us, i.e., for those in the province of adjudication and determination of disputes, this by-product of AI, i.e., the production of fake, non-existent, and



Even if an iota of fake or hallucinated material enters the decision-making process, it would violate the sanctity of adjudication. It is absolutely necessary to maintain integrity in decision-making, and we reiterate and declare zero tolerance for the Bar as well as the Bench to cite, refer to, or rely on such material

SUPREME COURT BENCH

hallucinated material and its utilisation as precedents in law, is like the release of methyl isocyanate in the province of law and justice: invisible, insidious, and catastrophic by the time anyone notices,” the Bench said.

The top court called for a “deeper collaboration” between the Bar and the Bench on AI and urged the Bar Council of India to frame norms to address the issue of AI-generated precedents.

It noted that the process had already begun with the court publishing the Draft Regulations for Use of Artificial Intelligence in Courts, 2026, for public consultation.

The draft regulations provide that AI systems may function only in an assistive capacity and cannot supplant the role of judges. They also require disclosure of AI-assisted filings and prohibit the use of AI in judicial decision-making.

To address the growing instances of AI-generated hallucinated precedents being cited before courts, the Bench directed the (BCI), the apex statutory body regulating the legal profession, to constitute a committee to examine the issue and formulate appropriate norms.

The top court was hearing an appeal filed by Pooja Ramesh Singh, a suspended director of Essel Infra-projects Ltd., challenging

the NCLT decision to admit the company into the corporate insolvency resolution process on an application filed by Jammu and Kashmir Bank under Section 7 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code. The insolvency proceedings arose out of an alleged default in relation to a ₹200-crore credit facility extended by Jammu and Kashmir Bank to Pan India Utilities Distribution Company Ltd.

The Mumbai Bench of the NCLT admitted the insolvency application in August after recording a claimed default of ₹87.43 crore.

The order was subsequently affirmed by the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT).

Integrity of process
The apex court expressed surprise that the NCLAT had failed to notice that the NCLT's order relied on fictitious judicial precedents. It also cautioned that courts and tribunals should not “implicitly trust lawyers” with regard to authorities cited before them without independently verifying them.

The apex court held that the source of the lapse did not diminish its adverse impact on the integrity of the judicial process.

The court set aside the orders of both the NCLT and the NCLAT and remitted the matter to the tribunal for fresh consideration in accordance with law.

INBRIEF



Punjab Cabinet gives nod to amend land pooling policy

The Punjab Cabinet on Wednesday evening gave its approval to amend the State's land pooling policy whereby it would offer more benefits to landowners. Addressing mediapersons in Chandigarh on Thursday, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema said it has been decided that landowners will now get a commercial plot of 210 square yards as against 200 square yards for every one acre of land given under the pooling policy. If a landowner does not want to take the commercial plot, he will be entitled to a 1,630 square yard residential plot, as against the earlier provision of a 1,600 square yard plot, he said. PTI

J&K BJP demands stringent punishment in Sarla Bhat case

The Jammu and Kashmir unit of the BJP on Thursday demanded that all accused in the kidnapping and killing of young Kashmiri Pandit nurse Sarla Bhat in April 1990 should be put on trial and given stringent punishment to ensure complete justice. Addressing a press conference here, J&K BJP's chief spokesperson Sunil Sethi said Bhat was Kashmir's daughter and she represented its composite culture. "She, her family, the community and the whole of Kashmir had to wait for 36 years for justice. The justice is not complete; it is incomplete. Her killer is in Pakistan. The justice will be complete when he is brought here and put on trial," he said. PTI

Maharashtra govt. stays new RTI rules ahead of Anna's hunger strike

Veteran social activist had planned to start an indefinite hunger strike on Saturday at Ralegan Siddhi demanding a rollback; State govt. will restore the position as of June 11, says official

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

The Maharashtra government on Thursday stayed the recent amendments to the Right to Information rules, two days before social activist Anna Hazare was to start an indefinite hunger strike at Ralegan Siddhi demanding a rollback. "We will restore the position as of June 11, 2026," a senior IAS officer told *The Hindu*. The government said the amendments had been stayed in view of the objections and concerns raised by Mr. Hazare.

'Moment of happiness'
The villagers of Ralegan Siddhi had called for an agitation on Friday, where they were to burn the draft of the Maharashtra Right to Information (Amendment) Rules, 2026. They expressed joy on news of the government's decision. "It is a moment of happiness for us. It would have been



The Fadnavis government said the amendments had been stayed in view of the objections raised by Anna Hazare. FILE PHOTO

difficult to see Anna sit for a hunger strike at the age of 90. The village stands by him," said a close associate of the activist. A letter sent by the General Administration Department on Thursday to the Chief Information Commissioner of Maharashtra stated: "The Chief Minister has directed that the rules before the issuance of a gazette notification on June 12, 2026, should be brought into force. Accordingly, the action has been taken immediately." Soon thereafter,

the Maharashtra State Information Commission issued orders staying the Maharashtra Right to Information (Amendment) Rules, 2026. Several activists had raised objections to the provisions of the amended rules, which included a threefold increase in application fee, the introduction of a new fee for appeals, and a cap on free information for those living below the poverty line. The rules also required that each RTI application pertain to a single subject

and be limited to 150 words. Other provisions included mandatory disclosure of an applicant's identity, removing anonymity protections for whistleblowers, barring legal representation during hearings, permitting dismissal of cases if applicants fail to appear, and closing cases upon an applicant's death. Reacting to the development on Thursday, RTI activist Vijay Kumbhar welcomed the decision to stay the amendments but also called for their scrapping. "They are in contravention to the provisions of the RTI Act. The government should appoint a new committee to look into this issue. It should include all stakeholders and be done transparently," he said. Maharashtra's Chief Information Commissioner Rahul Pande said a team had visited Mr. Hazare on June 24 where the activist conveyed his objections. "Accordingly the CM has directed to stay the implementation of the rules."

Bengal approves panel to examine draft UCC Bill

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The West Bengal Cabinet on Thursday approved the constitution of a committee headed by retired Supreme Court judge Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai to examine the draft Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill. Minister Agnimitra Paul said the panel would have four weeks to scrutinise the draft legislation and submit its recommendations. "The Cabinet has approved the formation of a committee to examine the West Bengal Uniform Civil Code, 2026, draft Bill. The committee will have four weeks to examine it, after which it will be placed in the Assembly," Ms. Paul told reporters after the Cabinet meeting.

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on June 29 informed the Assembly that UCC would be implemented in the State soon and had referred to the setting up of the committee to examine the draft UCC Bill. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), in its election manifesto, had promised implementation of the UCC within six months of coming to power.

According to sources, UCC is likely to ban polygamy, enforce gender parity in ancestral property rights, and curb child marriage. The proposed law is likely to bring in live-in relationships under its ambit and suggest registrations. The Bill is likely to be brought in the Assembly in August. The State government will take inputs from similar legislation in Assam, Uttarakhand and Gujarat. The government has also said Adivasi communities will be kept outside the ambit of the UCC.

TMC opposes UCC
Both the factions of the Trinamool Congress have opposed the implementation of the UCC in the State. Trinamool Congress chairperson and former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has asked party leaders to oppose the Bill both inside and outside the Assembly. Leader of the Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee, who leads the TMC's rebel faction, has also questioned the government's haste, arguing that a proposal touching family laws and personal rights should undergo extensive public discussion before being enacted.

Congress says Datia bypoll announced in 'a rush'; was EC's decision claims BJP

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The Congress on Thursday criticised the announcement of a byelection in Madhya Pradesh's Datia Assembly constituency, which had fallen vacant after the disqualification of Congress's Rajendra Bharti in April following his conviction in a fraud case. The Election Commission of India (EC) has announced that bypoll in Datia will be held on July 30, along with one Assembly seat each in Bihar and Gujarat. While the last date to file nominations is July 13, the votes will be counted on August 3. Datia holds significance as Bharti won the seat in the 2023 election after defeating BJP heavyweight and then Home Minister of Madhya Pradesh Narottam Mishra in a fiercely fought contest. Bharti's legislative mem-



Umang Singhar. FILE PHOTO

bership was, however, cancelled on April 2, a day after he was sentenced to three years in prison for cheating a co-operative bank by a special MP/MLA court in Delhi. He has challenged the verdict in the Delhi High Court and sought a stay, which is scheduled for hearing on July 8. Speaking to *The Hindu*, Bharti said the byelection has been announced "in a rush" while accusing the EC of "double standards". Bharti said the Commission had deferred byelection in Uttar Pradesh's Milkpur seat in November 2024 due to a pending election petition by the BJP candidate who had lost during the 2022 Assembly poll.

'EC's double standards'
While the Milkpur Assembly seat had fallen vacant after the Samajwadi Party MLA Awadhesh Prasad won the Lok Sabha poll, the bypoll was only held in February 2025 after the petition in the Allahabad High Court was withdrawn by the BJP leader. "This clearly shows the EC's double standards. They should have waited for the High Court's decision as they did in Milkpur. Has the EC assumed that the courts will rule against me," Bharti asked. Leader of Opposition in the Assembly Umang Singhar highlighted the case of Bina MLA Nirmala Sapre who had won on a Con-

gress ticket and is currently facing disqualification proceedings before the M.P. High Court after she unofficially switched over to the BJP in 2024. Mr. Singhar had moved to the HC seeking her disqualification from the Assembly. He said there has been no decision on Ms. Sapre's case for nearly two years. "Datia is an important place. Rajendra Bharti defeated a big BJP leader in 2023. Now, the BJP wants to capture this seat by hastily conducting a byelection," he said. Cabinet Minister and senior BJP leader Kailash Vijayvargiya said it was the EC's responsibility to hold the bypoll on the seat. "Any Assembly or Lok Sabha seat could not have been left vacant without a representative for a long time," he said addressing reporters in Bhopal, adding that a decision on the candidate was yet to be taken.

AIADMK ex-Minister C. Vijayabaskar, other functionaries join TVK in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The exodus of influential regional leaders from the AIADMK continued on Thursday, with former Ministers C. Vijayabaskar and M.R. Vijayabhaskar, several other senior functionaries, and thousands of cadres joining Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay-led Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam (TVK), dealing a fresh blow to the Dravidian major. In the presence of TVK general secretary and Minister for Rural Development and Water Resources N. Anand, general secretary (election campaign management) and Minister for Public Works and Sports Development Aadhav Arjuna, and other Ministers, they joined the ruling party at a private resort in Mamallapuram, nearly 60 km south of Chennai. Dr. Vijayabaskar, who had been associated with



AIADMK leaders joining the TVK in the presence of Ministers N. Anand and Aadhav Arjuna on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the AIADMK since his college days and served as the Health Minister between 2013 and 2021 in the Cabinets headed by former Chief Ministers Jayalalithaa, O. Panneerselvam, and Edappadi K. Palaniswami, resigned his Assembly membership on June 16. He was elected to the Tamil Nadu Assembly from Pudukkottai in 2001 and from Virallimalai in 2011, 2016, 2021, and 2026. Dr. Vijayabaskar was a strong-

man of the AIADMK in Pudukkottai district. **Part of rebel group**
His namesake (M.R. Vijayabhaskar), who hails from Karur, served as Transport Minister from 2016 to 2021. He won the Karur Assembly seat in 2016 and 2026, both by narrow margins. He resigned as MLA on June 29. Both of them were part of the group of 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs who voted

in favour of the Vijay-led government during the vote of confidence in the Assembly on May 13, defying the party whip. Former AIADMK Ministers M.S.M. Anandan and S. Valarmathi also joined the TVK. Mr. Anandan won the 2011 election from the Tiruppur North Assembly segment and served as Forest Minister. He won the Palladam seat in 2021 and lost to TVK's V. Sathyabama, who earlier served as the Tiruppur MP (2014-19) on an AIADMK ticket, in the 2026 election from Tiruppur North. Ms. Valarmathi was elected to the Assembly from the Srirangam in the 2015 byelection, necessitated following the conviction (later acquitted) of former CM Jayalalithaa in a disproportionate assets case. Ms. Valarmathi also won the same seat in 2016 and served as Backward Classes Welfare Minister.

Gujarat HC questions govt. on 'illegal demolition' in Surat

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

The Gujarat High Court on Thursday sought the State government's stand on the "completely illegal" demolition carried out in Narisnagar locality of Surat on May 30 resulting in around 100 houses being razed without any prior notice. The HC asked the government whether it was not responsible for its citizens and said an inquiry should have been carried out at the level of some one much senior to the Municipal Commissioner. Hearing a plea filed by some affected persons whose houses were razed by the Surat Municipal Corporation, Justice Nikhil Kariel asked the government as to what was its stand on this "completely illegal"

demolition. The HC also posed an oral question to the Police Commissioner on absence of complaint and investigation in the matter, despite a DCP-level officer being present at the site. **'Probe conducted'**
In his affidavit, the Municipal Commissioner informed the court that a preliminary inquiry carried out by the civic body's Deputy Municipal Commissioner opined that further inquiry was required as officers concerned were not coming out with the truth. It added that five officers who were present at the site when demolition was being carried out have been suspended. "This cannot be a one-off incident. If your officer

has the audacity to do something like this - a 100 houses, god knows how much you have done which has not yet come out," it said. The court also wanted to know as to how the Municipal Commissioner plans to rehabilitate the people who were rendered homeless. The Municipal Commissioner, in his affidavit, said the plot belonged to private individuals who had sought to develop it through third parties, and on March 12 this year a plot validation certificate was sought, which was rejected. When the developer requested for a physical demarcation of the street line, some SMC officers had intimidated the police authorities on May 30.

Madras HC refuses to quash case against Ponmudy over derogatory speech in 2025

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Thursday refused to set aside a private complaint lodged by Uma Anandan, a BJP councillor in the Greater Chennai Corporation, against former DMK Minister K. Ponmudy over the derogatory comments he made last year against Saivites, Vaishnavites, and women. Justice G.K. Ilanthirayan dismissed a criminal revision petition filed by the former Minister against the private complaint, lodged for alleged offences under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which the III Metropolitan Magistrate's Court at George Town in Chennai had taken cognisance of earlier this year.



K. Ponmudy

On February 23, the Magistrate had ordered the issuance of summons to the former Minister and hence, he had approached the High Court with the present revision petition in March, claiming that what he had said during a closed-door meeting was only a recall of certain statements made by another person several years ago, and was not from his own imagination. In her complaint, Ms.

Anandan had stated that she had come across a YouTube video of the Minister's speech at an event in Chennai in April 2025. She found it to be highly distasteful, and intended at promoting enmity between different groups of people, besides being prejudicial to the maintenance of harmony. She said that Mr. Ponmudy had, in the speech delivered during his stint as Forest Minister, recalled an incident of a person having likened the *pattai* (a horizontal symbol displayed by Saivites on their forehead) and *tiruman* (a vertical symbol sported by Vaishnavites on their forehead) to sexual postures by a sex worker. As the speech amounted to wounding the religious feelings of the two sects professing Hinduism,

besides falling under the definition of hate speech, the complainant said she had initially approached the police. But the police closed her complaint, and therefore, she had chosen to approach the Magistrate by way of a private complaint. Opposing her plea before the Magistrate, the counsel for the former Minister had contended that the complainant had not made out the commission of any offence under Sections 196(i)(a) (promoting enmity between different groups), 299 (deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings), or 302 (uttering words with intent to wound religious feelings) of the BNS, 2023, and hence, the complaint was not maintainable.

Ex-Trinamool Cong. MLA's husband held in graft case

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

A team of the Special Task Force of West Bengal Police has arrested Debraj Chakraborty, the husband of former Trinamool Congress MLA Aditi Munshi, in a case relating to alleged disproportionate assets, officials said on Thursday. The development came days after the Calcutta High Court granted anticipatory bail to Ms. Munshi in the same case on June 24, holding that she has a four-month-old child. The court denied the same for her husband while also directing his wife, a singer-turned-politician, to surrender her passport before a lower court and cooperate with the investigation.



CMYK A IN-X

Navy foils piracy attempt in Gulf of Aden; three vessels still in captivity, IMO warns

The Internet Freedom Foundation, a Delhi-based digital rights advocacy group, called the pressure on the messaging plat-

The *Golden Arsenal* operation is the latest in a series of anti-piracy patrols the Indian Navy has sustained in the Gulf of Aden and the wider Western Indian Ocean amid what the IMO has described as a resurgence of piracy and armed robbery against ships in the region.

Part of newly built Delhi-Dehradun Expressway caves in after rainfall

GUWAHATI

NEW DELHI

The damaged stretch was identified during routine patrols and repaired immediately, allowing traffic to continue uninterrupted, according to the NHAI. A balancing culvert meant

As M.P. judge faces online fury, case to protect judicial officers languishes in Supreme Court

NEW DELHI



Bombay HC upholds helmet exemption for Sikh community

Byelections in 3 Assembly constituencies on July 30

According to the schedule announced by the Election Commission, the Gazette notification for the byelections will be issued on July 6. July 13 is the last date for filing nominations, and the last date for withdrawal of candidature is July 16. Counting of votes will be held on August 3.

Wangchuk's health worsens on fifth day of hunger strike

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Activist Sonam Wangchuk's health deteriorated on the fifth day of his hunger strike at Jantar Mantar on Thursday, with his blood sugar level dropping to 60 and his blood pressure remaining low. The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) alleged that police assaulted students attempting to set up a library at the protest site, and the agitation received fresh backing from CPI(ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya and RTI activist Nikhil Dey.

In a post on X, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said Mr. Wangchuk's condition was "continuously deteriorating" and warned that the government would be responsible if anything happened to him, reiterating the demand for Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation.

Mr. Dipke also held an interaction with protesters titled "*Chai Pe Charcha* with Cockroaches", saying it was aimed at gathering feedback to make the movement bigger.

Six students part of All India Students' Association (AISA) continued their indefinite hunger strike. According to AISA, some of them were at risk of losing consciousness.

Govt. rolls out VB-G RAM G scheme from A.P. village

Union Agriculture Minister takes part in launch event at Mukkavaripalli village in Tirupati district; Chief Minister says spending funds on the scheme is 'not a burden but a responsibility' of States

A.D. Rangarajan
TIRUPATI

The little-known Mukkavaripalli village in Tirupati district of Andhra Pradesh shot to fame on Thursday with the nationwide launch of the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar Ajeevika Mission Grameen (VB-G RAM G) scheme.

Union Minister for Agriculture Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, and Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan launched the scheme by laying the foundation stone for a farm pond, to signal that the new rural employment guarantee scheme gives top priority to farmers' welfare, besides rural development.

Later, Mr. Naidu and Mr. Chouhan launched the VB-G RAM G portal. The scheme replaces the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme.

Speaking on the occasion, Mr. Chouhan said Prime Minister Narendra Modi aimed to build 74,212 houses in Andhra Pradesh under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, and had sanctioned funds for linking



A.P. Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan launch the VB-G RAM G scheme on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A.P. CM says ₹7,700 cr. will be given by Centre and ₹4,000 cr. will be borne by State for the scheme

ing villages through 146 rural roads. "With ₹422 crore earmarked for Andhra Pradesh, the Indian government is keen to develop roads and pucca houses in the State," he said.

Mr. Naidu said works would be taken up with an outlay of ₹7,700 crore from the Centre and another

₹4,000 crore coming from the State. He asserted that roping in States to spend funds on this scheme was "not a burden but responsibility".

Complete transparency "With 125 work days, any work required for rural development will have scope under VB-G RAM G. We will utilise this scheme to create assets such as roads, drainages, canals and others," Mr. Naidu said.

The Chief Minister added that the scheme would be implemented with complete

transparency by deploying technologies such as geo-tagging and biometrics.

The delegates later planted saplings of 10 varieties, such as teak, neem, and eucalyptus, at the venue. Mr. Pawan Kalyan, who holds the Panchayat Raj portfolio in the State, designed the project to plant tree varieties that yield wood, to earn revenue for the panchayats in future. He also explained the idea of a Wood Bank to Mr. Chouhan. (With PTI inputs)

EC seeks responses from both Trinamool factions on organisational elections

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission has sought responses from the rival factions of the Trinamool Congress regarding "claims and counter claims" made by them with respect to organisational elections and authorised signatories.

The two sides, one led by former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and the other by rebel leader Ritabrata Banerjee, have been asked to submit their responses by 5.30 p.m. on Monday, sources in the EC said on Thursday.

Earlier in the day, a full Bench of the poll body met leaders of the rebel faction led by Mr. Ritabrata. However, leaders loyal to Ms. Mamata questioned the EC's decision to grant an audience to the rebel faction, alleging that the meeting violated the poll body's own procedures of granting appointments to only authorised signatories of a recognised political party. "The EC had informed all parties about their rule where only authorised representatives of parties can request a meeting with a full Bench of the EC. We have not asked for any meeting. On what



The Ritabrata Banerjee-led faction of Trinamool Congress addresses media after meeting EC in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

grounds is the EC meeting the breakaway MLAs of the party? We decide who represents our party. Gyanesh Kumar [Chief Election Commissioner] has no role or power to decide for us," Trinamool MP Saugata Roy said.

After the meeting with the EC, Mr. Ritabrata said the 10-member delegation led by him had formally placed its case before the poll panel, after informing it of the faction's special organisational session held in Kolkata on June 22.

The commission gave them a "patient hearing" on their claim over the party, he said, expressing hope that the poll body would respond shortly.

Even as he declined to disclose the documents

submitted to the EC, Mr. Ritabrata said the rebel faction had "abided by all rules" while conducting the June 22 organisational session.

"The All India Trinamool Congress had a special session in Kolkata on June 22. Immediately after the session, we formally informed the EC about it in writing. We also met the Election Commission in Kolkata and sought an appointment with the Election Commission of India," he said, adding that this was part of the prescribed procedure, and that the faction had already completed the process.

Mr. Ritabrata reiterated the faction's claim that it represented the "real" Trinamool Congress.

Rabri gives up official bungalow, moves to own house in Patna

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA

Former Bihar Chief Minister Rabri Devi finally vacated her official residence on 10 Circular Road in Patna on Thursday. She had been living there along with her family members, including former Bihar Chief Minister and Rashtriya Janata Dal supremo Lalu Prasad, for about 20 years. The family shifted to their own house in the State capital.

Earlier, the BJP-led NDA government had issued several notices to Ms. Devi to vacate the bungalow as it had been allotted to the Dairy, Fisheries and Animal Resources Minister Nand Kishor Ram.

Ms. Devi has been given a bungalow on 39 Harding Road, where renovation work is on.

On Thursday afternoon,

the family informed the State Building Construction Department that it was vacating the Circular Road property.

Bungalow row

Ms. Devi being asked to vacate the bungalow had become a political rallying point for her party.

When the State government had issued the last notice asking the leader to vacate by June 29, Ms. Devi had dared the government to "evict her from the bungalow using force". Later, Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary said that those occupying the official bungalow have to vacate "at any cost". On Wednesday, Mr. Tejashwi said that "politics should not happen" on the issue but added that "even those who do not deserve, have been provided government residences".

Ram temple row: Venugopal writes to PM seeking SC-monitored probe

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Stepping up the Congress's attack over the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, party general secretary K.C. Venugopal on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking an immediate Supreme Court-monitored probe into what he described as the "Chanda Chori mega scandal".

In his letter, Mr. Venugopal alleged that the fraud involved "hundreds of crores" and amounted to a "monumental betrayal" of the Hindu faith, religion, and way of life.

He also questioned the credibility of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) constituted by the Uttar Pradesh government, saying it appeared to be little more than an "eyewash".



K.C. Venugopal

He further alleged that there was a growing apprehension that the probe was being used to erase the remaining evidence while shielding the "big fish" behind the alleged multi-crore embezzlement.

Alleging that the preliminary investigation had exposed a highly organised racket operating "right under the nose" of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, Mr. Venugopal

said the "systemic lapses at every level" suggested that the alleged loot had been enabled by institutional support.

"On one hand, the counting staff bypassed regular surveillance to siphon off bundles of cash and valuable jewellery on a daily basis; on the other, 7 to 8 months of crucial CCTV footage was deliberately destroyed... This clearly indicates that... this is a scam orchestrated with the complicity of the higher-ups instead," he alleged.

Complaints suppressed

Mr. Venugopal also claimed that complaints of embezzlement and theft were either ignored or actively suppressed. "The Trust's former Chief Accounts Officer, who flagged these systematic irregularities as early as 2020-21 and warned that unaccounted

gold and silver ornaments were being spirited away, was unceremoniously removed from his duties instead of being heard," he said.

Mr. Venugopal said "this scandal" warrants the highest level of accountability because the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust is a public trust constituted by the Government of India in 2020.

"A State-appointed SIT is neither equipped nor institutionally independent to investigate individuals wielding immense political and institutional influence," he said.

"Therefore, I strongly demand your immediate intervention in this matter to order a free and fair investigation by a high-level independent agency under the strict supervision of the Hon'ble Supreme Court of India," he said.

Wish there was an antidote to insecurities, Manish Tewari says after Punjab Cong. revamp

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Manish Tewari on Thursday posted a cryptic message on social media after being left out of the party's organisational reshuffle in Punjab, saying he wished he had "an antidote for the insecurities of individuals and institutions".

Mr. Tewari, the Chandigarh MP and former Union Minister, shared on X *The Hindu's* report on the Congress's Punjab revamp, which said he had been "left in the cold" as the party announced new working presidents and election panels ahead of the 2027 Assembly election.

"Hai bada koi avgun



Manish Tewari

usme jise koi hunar aave (loosely translated as 'if a person is talented, society usually finds fault with him')," Mr. Tewari wrote on social media platform X.

Without elaborating on the remark, he added that the Congress had given him "enough over the past 45 years" and that he had devoted his entire adult life

to the service of the party.

The Congress had on Wednesday announced its election-related committees for Punjab ahead of the 2027 Assembly election, while retaining Amarinder Singh Raja Warring as president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee and Partap Singh Bajwa as leader of the Congress Legislature Party, ending speculation over a possible leadership change in the State unit.

Former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi was appointed chairman of the campaign committee, while former Deputy Chief Minister Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa was named chairperson of the core committee.

2 J&K clerics denied nod to travel to Iran for Khamenei funeral

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Two Kashmir Shia clerics were denied permission to travel to Iran, a day after the Iranian International Relations Department invited them to attend the final rites of assassinated leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

J&K Anjuman-e-Sharie Shian president Aga Syed Hassan Al-Mosavi Al-Safavi was stopped by the Bureau of Immigration on Thursday.

"Officials seized his passport, and prevented him from boarding the flight despite all requisite travel documents, including a valid passport, visa, and confirmed travel arrangements," said a spokesman

of the organisation. "No explanation or written order was furnished to justify the action," he said.

The Shia organisation called upon the authorities concerned "to immediately clarify the circumstances under which this action was taken".

Another Shia cleric Masroor Abbas Ansari was also "denied a passport".

Five Shia clerics and former Chief Minister and Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti are among those invited by Iran to attend the burial ceremonies of assassinated Iranian supreme leader in an Israeli strike on February 28 this year.

Ms. Mufti is likely to visit Iran "to pay her respects".

J&K CM Omar Abdullah backs efforts to resume dialogue between India and Pakistan

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday backed initiatives seeking resumption of dialogue between India and Pakistan, saying "his party wants relations between neighbours to improve".

Referring to the joint open letter signed by over 100 individuals from India and Pakistan, Mr. Abdullah said, "A request is being made to the Prime Minister via a letter to find a way to improve relations between the two countries. Recently, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat stated that India and Pakistan should talk to each other and establish



Omar Abdullah

friendly ties. No one objects when the RSS says it."

'No objection'

Recalling the statement made by former Prime Minister, the late BJP leader Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Mr. Abdullah said, "Mr. Vajpayee would say 'one can change friends but not neighbours'. We also want

relations between neighbours to improve."

He said cross-border tensions between India and Pakistan had persisted for decades and worsened after the Pahalgam terror attack last year.

"The recent appeal reflects a sentiment that has long been expressed across the political spectrum. If calls for peace and engagement are welcomed from some quarters, they should not become controversial when voiced from Jammu and Kashmir," he said.

Mr. Abdullah added there should be no objection to advocating dialogue and normalisation of relations between India and Pakistan.

INBRIEF



Police move SC against Sonam Raghuvanshi's bail

The Meghalaya Police on Thursday moved the Supreme Court seeking an immediate stay on the bail granted to Sonam Raghuvanshi, the prime accused in the alleged murder of her husband, Raja Raghuvanshi, during their honeymoon in Meghalaya in May 2025. Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the State, mentioned the matter before a vacation Bench comprising Justices M. M. Sundresh and Sheel Nagu and sought an urgent hearing. The law officer pointed out that the Meghalaya High Court on June 29, had upheld an order of a Shillong trial court granting bail to Ms. Sonam. He argued that there was a plausible risk of the accused absconding.

Centre amends drug rules to ensure uniform regulations

Aimed at strengthening regulatory oversight of advanced and emerging medical technologies, the Central government has amended the Drugs Rules, 1945 to bring stem cell derived products, gene therapeutic products, and xenografts under the ambit of the Centrally License Approving Authority (CLAA) framework. These include vaccines, large volume parenterals and r-DNA based medicines. This set is being expanded with this amendment to cover additional emerging technologies, said Ministry on Thursday.

15 papers fail to help Assam man prove his citizenship

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Days after the External Affairs Ministry clarified that a passport was not proof of citizenship, a 38-year-old resident of Assam could not convince the Gauhati High Court that 15 other documents he possessed were sufficient to establish him as an Indian, not a foreigner.

On June 30, a Bench of Justice Kalyan Rai Surana and Justice Shamima Jahan upheld an order of a Foreigners' Tribunal declaring Aminul Hoque, a daily-wage labourer, a non-citizen, citing inconsistencies in the documents he produced to claim his citizenship. These included a copy of the 1951 National Register of Citizens featuring his father and grandparents, voter identity cards, a permanent account number, a school certificate, and an original land purchase deed of 1973.

Amarnath pilgrims reach base camp ahead of yatra

The first batch of more than 4,800 pilgrims has set off from Jammu in a convoy of 259 vehicles, officials say; security on the twin routes has been stepped up using AI technology and drones

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

A year after the Pahalgam attack saw a dip in pilgrim footfall, Jammu & Kashmir Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha on Thursday flagged off the first batch of devotees for the pilgrimage to the Amarnath holy cave from the Bhagwati Nagar Base Camp in Jammu.

Pilgrims started reaching the twin base camps – Nunwan at Pahalgam in south Kashmir and at Baltal in Sonamarg – a day ahead of the formal trek to the ice (stalagmite) *lingam* at an altitude of 3,880 metres. “I wish all devotees a safe, comfortable, blissful and spiritually fulfilling journey. May this holy pilgrimage bring immense joy and divine peace to all,” Mr. Sinha said, wishing the pilgrims.

Every year, the J&K administration, Shri Amarnath Shrine Board, J&K Police, Indian Army, security forces, local community, and all stakeholders join hands to make the pil-



All set: Pilgrims waiting for registration at the Baltal Base Camp in Sonamarg on Thursday, where they will spend the night before proceeding to the Amarnath shrine. IMRAN NISSAR

grimage a success.

However, the Pahalgam terror attack, which left 26 civilians dead in April 2025, also impacted the pilgrimage later in the year.

The first batch of more than 4,800 pilgrims has set off on the holy yatra in a convoy of 259 light and heavy vehicles, officials said.

The Baltal route is a steep, 14-km one-way trek. The Pahalgam route is a

34-km trek, with the Mahagunas Top at 4,276 m.

Upgraded security

Security on the pilgrimage routes has been stepped up this year. Artificial Intelligence technologies and drones have been deployed to maintain a vigil.

J&K Apni Party president Altaf Bukhari conveyed his wishes to the devotees. “This annual pilgrimage has always been

a shining symbol of Jammu and Kashmir's rich composite and inclusive culture. It reflects our cherished values of faith, harmony, mutual respect, and hospitality,” he said.

The people of Jammu and Kashmir, especially the Muslim community, have always played a vital role in ensuring the safe, smooth, and hassle-free conduct of the pilgrimage, the leader said.

House panel pulls up Education Secretary over CBSE remarks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A heated argument erupted in Parliament's Public Accounts Committee (PAC) on Thursday, after Education Secretary Vineet Joshi sought to prevent questions being posed to the Central Board of Secondary Education, saying the Board fell outside the panel's agenda for the day.

The CBSE has come under fire in recent months for serious discrepancies in the on-screen marking system for its Class 12 examination and the award of the digital evaluation contract to a questionable firm.

The PAC, chaired by senior Congress leader K. C. Venugopal, was meeting to review the implementation of welfare schemes of the Union Education Ministry. Mr. Joshi later withdrew his remarks after pushback from Mr. Venugopal and several others, including some BJP MPs.

‘No questions allowed’

The Education Secretary started by delivering a presentation on various schemes, including Sama-

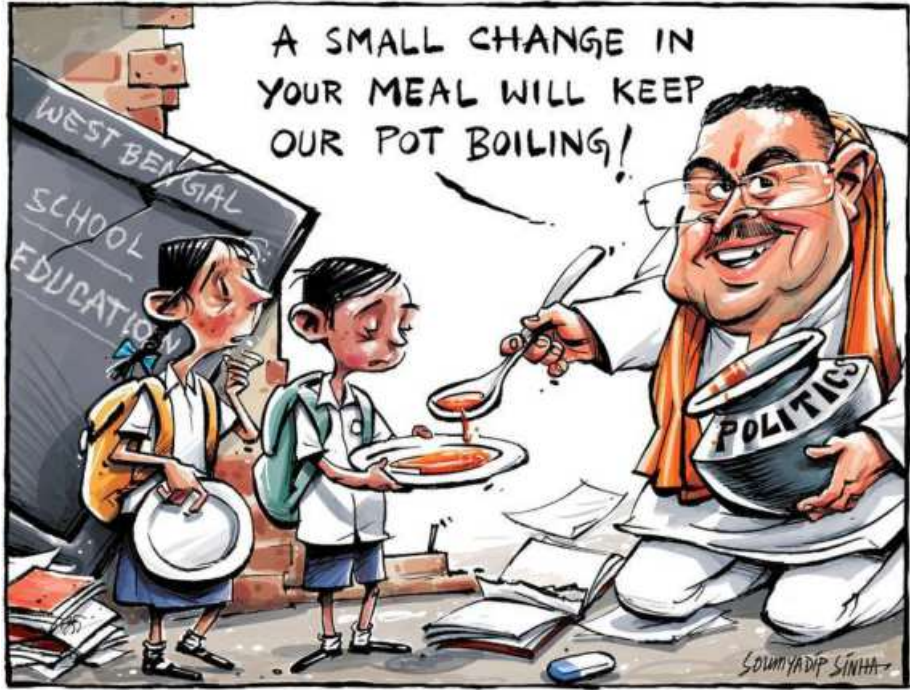
gra Shiksha Abhiyan, PM SHRI, and PM POSHAN. Mr. Joshi then said, according to sources, that no questions could be directed to CBSE Chairperson Lokhande Prashant Sitaram, who was also present at the meeting, as the Union government does not provide grants or funding to the CBSE.

According to sources, Mr. Venugopal said that the CBSE could submit written responses later. In response, Mr. Joshi, speaking on behalf of Mr. Sitaram, said that the CBSE would need to consult the Law Ministry before answering the panel's questions.

Outrage from MPs

The remark led to an uproar. According to sources, Mr. Venugopal said that dismissing the panel's questions amounted to an insult to Parliament. BJP MPs K. Laxman and Aparajita Sarangi also supported the Chairperson, saying the PAC could take up any issue of public importance. When members insisted that the exchange be placed on record, Mr. Joshi withdrew his comments, sources said.

On the draw



Railways sees 4% growth in freight

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Railways registered steady growth in both freight transportation and passenger services during June 2026, as compared with the corresponding

month last year, the Railway Ministry said in a statement.

The Railways loaded 142.21 million tonnes of freight during June 2026, compared with 136.71 million tonnes in the corresponding month last year,

registering a growth of 4%.

“Freight earnings also recorded healthy growth, generating an additional revenue of about ₹430 crore, an increase of 3 per cent over June 2025,” the Ministry added in the statement.

PF Rules notified; no word on hike in minimum pension, allege unions

A. M. Jigeesha
NEW DELHI

The Union Labour Ministry published on June 29 and 30 the Rules for the Employees Provident Fund (EPF) Scheme, 2026, the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS), 2026, and the Employees' Deposit Linked Insurance (EDLI) Scheme, 2026, replacing the old Rules of 1952.

The new Rules were required after the implementation of the Code on Social Security in November 2025. The Central Board of Trustees (CBT) had approved the draft Rules in its 239th meeting on March 2.

The Ministry had told the CBT that the notification of the new schemes will provide a legally sound framework under the Code and will enable incorporation of previously approved reforms.

The government said it will facilitate alignment of scheme provisions with the Code and remove ambigu-



The Ministry had said that the notification of the new schemes would provide a legally sound framework.

ty during the transition phase along with ensuring continuity and stability in administration of social security benefits.

Trade unions, however, said the notification does not reflect the demands of subscribers such as increase in minimum pension and clarity in providing higher pension for the applicants.

To align the application of the EPF Scheme with the Code, the Rule was amended so that it will be applicable to every establishment,

to which the Chapter III of the Code applies, and to every establishment belonging to or under the control of the Central or a State government.

In the EPS Rules, the current provision was that where the pay of the member exceeded ₹15,000 per month, the current wage ceiling limit for pension, the contribution for pension payable by the employer and the Central government will be limited to the amount payable on the employee's pay of ₹15,000 only.

In the new Rule, it has been amended as: “Provided that where the wage of the member exceeds the wage ceiling notified by the Central Government, the contribution payable by the employer and the Central Government shall be limited to the amount payable on wages up to such wage ceiling,” giving an indication that the government may revise the wage ceiling for pension, a de-

mand of the trade unions.

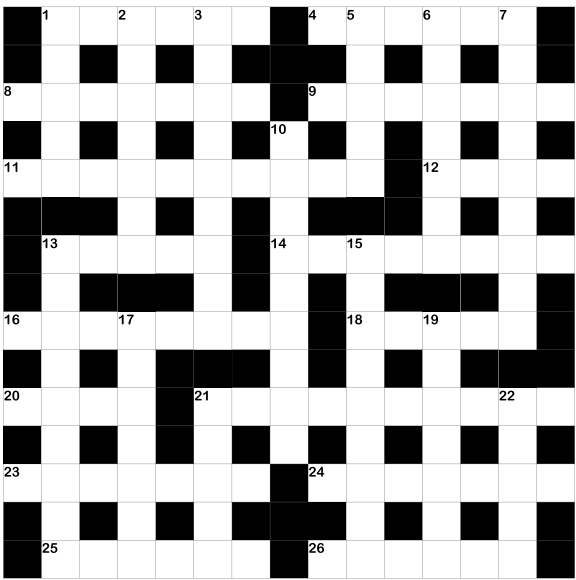
There is a minor amendment in the case of disbursing agencies of pension, which was earlier limited to agencies such as post offices, nationalised banks, treasuries or scheduled commercial banks including regional rural banks or co-operative banks.

In the EDLI Scheme Rules, the Centre has added definition of ‘insurance policy’, ‘commissioner’, ‘member’ and ‘nominee’.

Centre of Indian Trade Unions leader and worker's representative in the CBT R. Karumalaiyan told *The Hindu* that the amendments are cosmetic and the long-pending demands of increasing the minimum pension and addressing the problems in distributing higher pension were ignored by the government. “Also, the ceiling for pension, which was fixed in 2014, should have been changed,” he said.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14836
(set by Crossant)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>



ACROSS

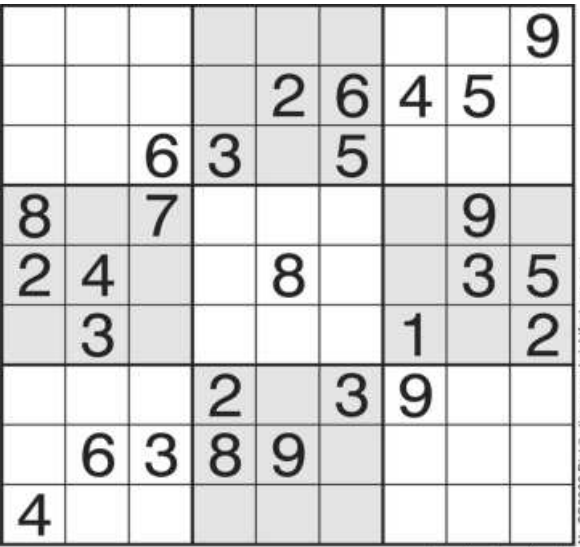
- Weak Queen refused to fast after start of summer (6)
- Warning boy to leave nasty, immoral habit (6)
- Mounting covert police operation to nab foreigner (7)
- Delighted when entering sanctuary in outskirts of Palakkad (7)
- Nicely go around flashing a new Tesla (10)
- Bird starting late gets worm? (4)

- Further education lags in that respect (5)
- U.S. never bothered about India and the world (8)
- Maybe Vasco da Gama from Portugal learning routes in the beginning (8)
- Military vehicles and tense, faceless rows of soldiers (5)
- Follow hooligan cycling around entrance of estate (4)
- In fact, session at home is fixed (10)
- Boy working hard without accomplishment ultimately gets extremely angry (7)
- What bowlers do when de Villiers bats - won't have slip mostly (7)
- Makes pens out of unhealthy styrene primarily (6)
- About to exit central building, understood? (6)

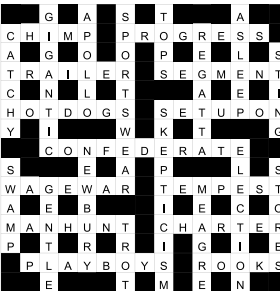
DOWN

- Is finally all right? Great. (5)
- Bit of cream soup (no piece of potato) and cheese maybe (7)
- Listen, leaders of national eminence lost and are angry (4,2,3)
- Lloyd botched an easy catch (5)
- Judge one with a drink in Middle East (7)
- Implements tariffs restricting export revenues in the beginning (9)
- Say most regressive, senseless last words perhaps (2,2,5)
- Revolutionary took best, essentially Marxist reading material (9)
- Check and re-enter if wrong (9)
- King and Queen maybe switching sides and allegiance (7)
- More curious about India becoming rowdier (7)
- Slow person needs backing from time to time (5)
- Equalise at the end of tight game (5)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

‘Bhagavan’, the apt title

When we say ‘Bhagavan’, it refers to Sriman Narayana, said Sri Desika Srinivasa Thathachariar in a discourse. How did Sriman Narayana get the title Bhagavan? What meaning do the scriptures give to this word? The word Bhagavan consists of two components, “*bhaga*” and “*vat*”. The suffix *vat* indicates possession, similar to possessing a quality. One who possesses *bhagam* is called Bhagavan. So what is the meaning of *bhaga*? Sastras define six auspicious attributes for the word *bhaga*. From the manifestation of these six primary attributes, all other auspicious qualities – such as Vatsalyam (compassion), Karu-nyam (mercy), Mardavam (gentleness), Hardam (affection), Shthairyam (stability), Dhairyam (courage) and Parakramam (valour) – originate.

The Lord possesses countless divine attributes. Among them, the most important are the six Kalyana Gunas. They are jnanam (knowledge), balam (strength), aishwaryam (lordship and sovereignty), veeryam (valour), shakthi (power), and Tejas (self-sufficiency). The above six attributes are known as the Lord's “*Paraavara Guna Shat-kam*”, the six foremost, primary, and essential qualities. Jnanam means he perceives all things at all times, simultaneously, directly, and by his own inherent nature. Balam refers to the immense power to sustain and bear everything without undergoing fatigue or strain. Aishwaryam is the capability to command, rule, and regulate everyone and everything. Veeryam emphasises that he remains completely unchanged in his inherent nature. Shakthi means the capability to make the impossible possible. Tejas explains that he is completely self-sufficient.

Can space oncology revolutionise cancer treatment?

A IN-X

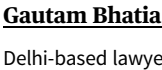


Read alongside the performance of India's eight core industries, which expanded by only about 2.8% in Q1 FY27 compared with around 6% in the corresponding period last year, the domestic economy appears more subdued. Growth has been expectedly weak in crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, fertilizers and electricity. The latest HSBC Manufacturing PMI reading of 54.2 likewise points to steady but moderating factory activity, marking the second-lowest expansion in 13 months. These figures come as India marks nine years of GST as a unified destination-based indirect tax. The government can point to the expansion of the tax base from about 66 lakh taxpayers in 2017 to over 1.65 crore today, reflecting better compliance, greater formalisation, and faster refunds, though input tax credit, litigation and federal balance in revenue sharing issues remain unresolved. GST has strengthened India's indirect tax architecture. Yet, the June numbers are a reminder that a growing share of the recent buoyancy appears to have been underwritten by imported inflation and a depreciating rupee rather than stronger domestic value addition.

AI holds scientific promise, but it should not unfold unchecked

AI firms acting irresponsibly have already caused harms that would not be tolerated in any other industry. AI models have ensnared teenagers and adults in parasocial fantasies that have sometimes turned fatal; they have flattened the world wide web, grievously injuring the news media's ability to deploy resources in their respective missions to inform the public; they have unleashed an epidemic of deepfakes, undermining trust in the written word and images alike; and they have deeply intertwined their promises of Artificial General Intelligence with global financial systems, with possible catastrophic economic consequences. The most important task for governments is how to hold these firms to account when needed, as taking a backseat on this conversation – even if industry leaders ignore the Global South's concerns – carries far greater costs. India has already experienced the cost of not asserting itself in the technology development of the decade: even as Anthropic's *Mythos* and Fable held out the tantalising promise of securing vast cyber systems, the U.S. pulled access, leaving the firms that had these models to ponder the risk of a different model succeeding at attacking their infrastructure. There is a limit to visions of AI as a geostrategic asset; much needs to be done to address its potential for broad damage.

Nor does the argument that the accused themselves might be responsible for delaying the trial hold any water. Whatever applications an accused (or, for that matter, the state) may make,



As proceedings
in the 2020
Delhi Riots
cases show,
endless
imprisonment
without trial
raises urgent
questions about
liberty
and justice

It is trite to say that no case is identical to the other. On an issue as basic as pre-trial incarceration, repeated inconsistencies across cases and courts undermine the rule of law and, ultimately, damage the cause of fundamental

Ultimately, therefore, this issue is both about individual human lives and about our commitment as a society to human and democratic values. As these cases continue to arise, the courts will once again have an opportunity to reaffirm these values, whether in individual bail cases before trial courts or when it comes to laying down the law before the Court. It is to be hoped that this happens, and that the cycle of endless imprisonment without trial is broken.

Aditi Garg
Collector and District
Magistrate, Mandsaur,
Madhya Pradesh

Himangka Kaushik,
New Delhi

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

It has become hard to make sense of what is happening in Tamil Nadu politics. The election result has redrawn the political landscape with parties such as the Congress, the CPI(M), the CPI, the VCK, the IUML and MDMK providing the TVK-led government its crutches, and the AIADMK imploding. The so-called ideological like-mindedness has given way to opportunism. What these parties did was not quite ethical. Saying that it was done to prevent the

imposition of President's rule was a lame excuse to rationalise their politically expedient move. It is most worrying that newly-elected AIADMK MLAs are tendering their resignations as MLAs and joining the TVK. If it is not TVK-style 'horse trading', what is it? The defections are no great advertisement to 'pure politics' that Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay professes to represent and uphold. The only plausible explanation for luring AIADMK MLAs is that the TVK does not want to rely on the support of the

Political morality, probity in

V. Johan Dhanakumar,
Chennai

The government's latest submission before the Supreme Court that ethanol blending remains an ongoing experiment raises many questions: if its full impacts are still being studied, why has ethanol-blended fuel become the default option for consumers, and why have concerns over

In the Editorial, "Yes and no" (July 2), the first sentence should have said "... based on Ministry of Panchayati Raj surveys".

The Readers' Editor's office can be contacted by Telephone:
+91-44-28576347/28576300; E-mail:readerseditor@thehindu.co.in

Has the expansion to 48 teams affected the quality of the World Cup?



Pradhyum Reddy

is a coach and commentator

PARLEY

In January 2017, when FIFA expanded the World Cup to 48 teams, starting with the 2026 edition, there were mixed feelings. Many welcomed the move, arguing that the flagship event of the planet's most popular sport should have more than just 32 outfits. But there was criticism too, for many felt that the increase would dilute the quality of football. What does evidence from the ongoing World Cup in North America say? **Pradhyum Reddy** and **Lallianzuala Chhangte** discuss this in a conversation moderated by **N. Sudarshan**. Edited excerpts:

How has the World Cup watching experience been so far?

Pradhyum Reddy: Apart from the time difference, it has been really enjoyable. Before the World Cup, there was talk about a lot of the negatives, but it is good to see the crowds. This is what makes the World Cup so interesting, like the stories about the Scottish fans in Boston and the colour that the African sides bring. Teams have caught us by surprise and that gulf with European and South American sides keeps getting smaller. Teams like Cape Verde and the Democratic Republic of Congo have made it really interesting.

Lallianzuala Chhangte: The biggest thing I have noticed is how competitive football has become. Every team is better prepared and there are very few easy games. From a player's point of view, it is really inspiring to see how much nations have progressed. It is really exciting to see more countries get the opportunity to compete on a bigger stage.

Many feared an abundance of one-sided contests. How do you rate the quality?

PR: There have not been many blowout games. It is good to see the so-called smaller countries coming through. There has been a lot of gate-keeping by European countries over the years. If it is called a World Cup, it should be representative of the world and not just five or six countries from South America and the European elite. Nine of the [10] African countries qualified for the second phase. The Asian countries started well, and then the gulf in quality became visible. But [overall], it has been good, and this is what inspires nations. Even from an Indian perspective, you will get fans who do not normally follow Indian football suddenly getting involved. It is a good gauge of where we are, and the direction in which world football is growing



Changes begin: Cape Verde, the third-smallest country to qualify, reached the knockout rounds. REUTERS

in terms of player quality and styles.

LC: The tournament has answered many doubts. Expanding the World Cup has given more nations a chance to dream bigger. I do not think the quality has suffered. In fact, it has been shown that the gap between many countries is getting smaller because football is developing everywhere.

Cape Verde, the third-smallest country to qualify, reached the knockout rounds. Only Mexico, Argentina and France won all three of their group-stage matches. Is this proof of the quality improving?

LC: Absolutely. It proves that football is not just about population or history anymore. With the right planning, right investment and belief, even smaller nations can compete with the best.

PR: One of the disadvantages of the 48-team World Cup is the way eight third-placed sides [from the group stage] go through. It leads to the situation where you are probably not going to have three wins like Argentina, Mexico and France because you can pretty much qualify after two wins.

That said, you cannot just play to get three draws because you have seen teams even with one win not go through. So there is an incentive to [get a win] and that is why you have seen some really good counter-attacking football. Players all over the world are very well prepared physically. So, if they can be defensively organised, the gulf narrows. That is the great leveler we have seen this time.

Asia doubled its slots for the 2026 World Cup, helping Uzbekistan and Jordan make the grade. They lost all their matches, but what effect can World Cup qualification have on a country?



Expanding the World Cup has given more nations a chance to dream bigger. It has been shown that the gap between many countries is getting smaller because football is developing everywhere

LALLIANZUALA CHHANGTE

PR: We should not look at the results of Uzbekistan and Jordan in a negative light. It is a massive achievement to qualify. Jordan was runner-up at the AFC Asian Cup (2023). Uzbekistan has done well at the U-17, U-20, and U-23 levels in Asia. So, if you can consistently challenge for your continental competitions, the pathway is there for success. Of course, countries that come in for the first time are not going to see success. You need one team to go far, like Morocco last time (semifinalist in 2022). That will inspire other teams to bridge the gap between themselves and the leaders in the region.

LC: When I look back at those matches we played [against Uzbekistan and others], I still feel jealous. But seeing Uzbekistan and Jordan feature in the World Cup also gives us hope. Qualification for the World Cup can transform football. It will inspire young players, attract more sponsors and big brands of the world, and it will improve infrastructure and encourage better youth development. The results did not go Uzbekistan's and Jordan's way, but experience at the highest level is invaluable.

Only two out of nine from the Asian zone made it to the round of 32. But nine of the 10 African nations progressed. What does it say about Asian football? Overall, do you think the sport is improving?

PR: A lot of the African players are playing in the top-five leagues of the world. That is the next stage of development for Asian football. African club football has not really grown as much as player development. But you look at Asia, there is a lot of focus on how the clubs have grown, whether they are successful in the AFC Champions League, etc. Even among the elite in Asia, like Japan and South Korea, many players are playing in Europe. They have got a striker [Ayase Ueda, Japan] who was the top scorer in the Eredivisie [Netherlands]. Once the rest of Asia can catch up in producing players who go on to play at that level, the gulf will reduce.

LC: Every continent is improving. Africa's performance shows what consistent investment

and player development can achieve. Most of the players from Africa are playing abroad. Asia has made progress too, but we still need greater consistency. Countries like Japan and Australia have shown what is possible with long-term planning. I think the gap with Europe and South America is getting smaller and smaller each year.

India is ranked 26th in Asia. When can we realistically expect to be at a World Cup?

PR: The simplest explanation is: you look at all the teams that have qualified, and they have gotten there by doing well consistently in their confederations. We have not qualified for the 2027 AFC Asian Cup. Qualification for the AFC competitions should become the norm. We have to be there at every single AFC U-23 and U-20 event. The [Indian] women just showed that they can do it. They were at the AFC U-17, U-20 and seniors. When our men's teams consistently compete at all age-group tournaments for at least 10 years, you are starting to build a group that could compete in a World Cup.

LC: We have not built an ecosystem consistently over a long period. There have been changes in directions, uncertainties with the league, challenges in youth development, infrastructure and grassroots football. These things do not improve overnight, but at the same time, it is not a reason to lose hope. We should not put a fixed timeline on qualifying because that creates unnecessary pressure. We should focus on improving year after year, and become consistently competitive in Asia first. Then, qualifying for the World Cup will become a realistic goal rather than just a dream.

As a player, how do you cope with the feeling of missing out?

LC: We were once close [to Uzbekistan], in terms of physicality and experience. One reason we are not catching up is that we don't have Indian-origin players playing here, and our players aren't taking the risk to play outside India. As coach Pradhyum mentioned, we need more players who play outside. For me, it might be too late. But the younger generation should go abroad and gain experience for at least four or five years. We need players who go out of their comfort zone, and that will put India in a better place.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

Bhagyaraj, Bharathiraja and the memories they left behind

Two filmmakers reshaped Tamil cinema with distinctive storytelling, memorable characters and authentic portrayals of human relationships

B. Kolappan

I vividly remember the night I went to watch K. Bhagyaraj's *Thoorai Ninnu Pochu*. I sat on the carrier of my cousin's bicycle as he pedalled against the stiff wind blowing from Putheri Lake in Kanniyakumari district. That night, we slept on the veranda of my cousin's neighbour's house and woke up to the scorching morning sun beating down on our faces, with the film still playing in my mind. Its unforgettable songs – especially *Erikkarai Poon-gatre* – have continued to echo in my ears even after decades.

The day Bhagyaraj died, I was in Thuk-kachi, a village near Kumbakonam. My Chief of Bureau, Ramya Kannan, alerted me to the news. I was stunned. Barely two weeks earlier, another of my favourite filmmakers, Bharathiraja, had passed away.

Bhagyaraj was an associate of Bharathiraja. Together, they transformed the grammar of Tamil cinema. Writing Bhagyaraj's obituary – and, before that, Bharathiraja's – came naturally to me because I had admired their work for decades. As a director, actor, scriptwriter, and dialogue writer, Bhagyaraj broke almost every convention of commercial filmmaking.

A gifted storyteller with an instinctive understanding of human relationships, he dethroned the larger-than-life hero and replaced him with the ordinary man from the street. He proved that charisma did not depend on a commanding screen presence or exaggerated heroics. Wit, intelligence, vulnerability and self-deprecating humour could be just as compelling. His films showed that an unassuming young man could win a woman's heart through ingenuity rather than machismo.

In *Indru Poi Naalai Vaa*, he and his friends are willing to do almost anything to win the affection of the heroine. Bhagyaraj's character accompanies the heroine's mother to the ration shop in the hope of getting closer to her family and even sketches a donkey because its milk is believed to cure the heroine's younger sister's ailment. Such scenes became believable

because of his extraordinary sense of humour and impeccable comic timing.

Bharathiraja, by contrast, dealt with more serious themes, capturing the emotional landscape of rural Tamil Nadu with remarkable sensitivity. His films were marked by dialogues that lingered long after the curtains came down. One such line that resonates with me is Sridevi's poignant declaration to Kamal Haasan in the closing moments of *16 Vayathinile*: “*Indha Mayilu Unakkagave Eppavume Kaathiruppa* (will always be waiting for you).”

In Bhagyaraj's *Suvar Illatha Chithirangal*, the comedy scenes featuring Kallapetti Singaram and Goundamani, spoken in authentic Kongu dialect, testify to his deep understanding of society. It was from that film that I learnt the word *siluvanam*, used to describe a naïve person. Equally unforgettable is the street-side tailor's lament: “*Veppankaikku kood irandu kaaka varuthu; enakku kadankaranthan vaaran* (At least a few crows visit the neem tree for its fruits, but I am visited only by money lenders).”

I watched most of the films of Bharathiraja and Bhagyaraj in touring talkies. Those humble theatres, the crackling projector, the smell of the earth spread on the floor, and the collective excitement of the audience whenever a punch dialogue was delivered made watching a film an unforgettable experience.

During the summer temple festivals in our villages, *naiyandi melam* troupes would often play songs from Bhagyaraj's films. Even today, whenever I come across such performances, I request them to play *Mookuthi Poomele* from *Mouna Geethangal* and *Kadhal Vaibhogame* from *Suvar Illatha Chithirangal*.

I watched *Mouna Geethangal* with a young girl, her father and her brother. By then, I had begun wearing spectacles like the child character in the film and was constantly ridiculed by my classmates. Yet I cherish that film for a very different reason. The girl who watched it with me would, years later, become my wife.

Kolappan.b@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Bowing out



Grace in exit: Japan's players bow to their supporters after a 2-1 defeat to Brazil in the FIFA World Cup 2026 Round of 32 match in Houston on June 29. AP

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 3, 1976

Advertisements should carry conviction: Dave

Madras, July 2: Mr. P. K. Dave, Adviser to the Governor, to-day asked the advertising profession to avoid high pressure campaigns where all kinds of tall claims are made for particular brands of consumer articles.

“The public is now getting wiser and perhaps more cynical with this kind of high pressure advertising,” he said. For common articles of consumption, manufactured virtually to common standards, he wondered

The Hindu.

what variations there were in real content. Delivering the presidential address at a symposium on “Credibility in Advertising” organised by the Advertising Club of Madras at Hotel Connemara, he said there was great scope for the profession. State Governments were vying with one another to promote programmes of industrialisation, sell their regions for industrialisation, to sell their industrial estates and so on. Besides, the printed word must teach the masses to tell them of their obligations as well as their duties.

Mr. Dave said advertising men should help carry the message of the 20-point programme to the masses. But he warned them against turning the campaign into “sloganeering”.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 3, 1926

Sea Scouts in Madras

This branch of scouting has not made much headway in the Presidency till now. But thanks to the efforts of Commander Digby-Beste R. I. M. of the Port Trust, serious attempts at starting a scout troop exclusively for sea scouting have become a success. The troop was organised a couple of months ago and more has been working vigorously and systematically. The idea of sea scouting was put before the Provincial Commissioner who granted permission to start a troop with the condition that precautions against accidents in boating or bathing should be taken. Commander Digby-Beste proceeded about the business properly and himself took a course of training in scout craft in the recent training camp conducted in “Rutland Gate”, Nungambakam.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount to be given by U.S. to Tanzania under five-year health pact

1.3 in \$ billion. The U.S. has signed an MoU with Tanzania to invest more than \$1.3 billion in its health sector over the next five years. The agreement, signed late on Wednesday, is similar to those struck with countries including Rwanda, Kenya, and Uganda under U.S. President Donald Trump's 'America First Global Health Strategy'. REUTERS

Official death toll in Ebola virus outbreak in DR Congo

438 The official toll in an Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo now exceeds 400, according to official figures released on Thursday. The highly contagious disease has claimed 438 lives, with 1,406 people infected since the outbreak was declared in northeastern Ituri province on May 15, National Institute of Public Health said in its latest report. AFP

Toll in communal clashes in Nigeria's Niger state

48 Communal violence in Nigeria killed at least 48 people on Wednesday, as per a security report. The report, prepared for the United Nations, said "herder militia" raided farmers from Kamuku ethnic group in the town of Tegna in Niger state. The state has already been reeling from violence by jihadists, kidnapping-for-ransom and cattle rustling gangs called bandits. AFP

Amount to be spent by Belgium on NASAMS and skyranger systems

3.1 in € billion. Belgium is planning to buy 10 advanced surface-to-air missile system (NASAMS) launchers from Kongsberg and 20 Skyranger short-range air defence systems from Rheinmetall for a total price of 3.1 billion euros, a Belgian official said on Thursday. The plans could be announced at a NATO summit in Ankara next week, the official said. REUTERS

Fine imposed on *Tagor* tanker by France

1 in € million. The French authorities on Thursday fined the *Tagor* tanker, which they intercepted and impounded at the end of May over its role in shipping Russian oil and gas, €1 million (\$1.1 million). The French Ministry of Justice added in a statement that the *Tagor* was now free to leave French waters following the payment of the fine. REUTERS

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Welfare promises and fiscal constraints

The West Bengal government's strategy relies on higher central transfers and a sharp rise in tax collections; if these projections fail to materialise, both its fiscal targets and political commitments could come under pressure

ECONOMIC NOTES

Subhanil Chowdhury

Riding on a historic mandate, the first BJP government of West Bengal presented its Budget on June 22. The BJP's election manifesto promised to provide ₹3000 per month to women, increase the Dearness Allowance for the State government employees to bridge the gap between the salaries at the Centre and State governments along with other commitments. The first Budget of the BJP government has tried to accommodate these pre-poll promises of the party, while simultaneously trying to reduce the fiscal deficit. The question is whether the expenditure and revenue allocations in the Budget will be able to do justice to the promises made by the government.

The government has budgeted a total expenditure of ₹4,28,557 crore in 2026-27 which is ₹82,083 crore more than the Revised Estimate (RE) of 2025-26. This huge expenditure is accompanied by a reduction in both fiscal deficit (from ₹67,774 crore in RE 2025-26 to ₹62,421 crore in Budget Estimate 2026-27) and revenue deficit (from ₹41,164 crore to ₹21,984 crore). How could the government increase its expenditure substantially, while reducing both the fiscal and revenue deficits? The answer lies in the so called "double engine sarkar".

If we look at the revenue receipts of the government, an increase of ₹75,618 crore is projected in 2026-27, as compared with RE 2025-26. This huge increase in revenue receipts is largely explained by a projected increase of ₹49,324 crore in the Centre's grant-in-aid to the State government, mainly via Centrally Sponsored Schemes. This bonanza of around ₹50,000 crore is the revenue impact of the so called 'double engine sarkar'. The government also projects an increase in the State taxes to the tune of ₹18,933 crore, non-tax revenue to increase by ₹4,508 crore and State's share of



Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, State Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta (right) and BJP MLA Anandamay Barman hold the Budget book at the State Legislative Assembly House, in Kolkata. ANI

central taxes to increase by ₹2,853 crore in 2026-27 as compared with RE 2025-26. While the total increase in revenue receipts is to the tune of ₹75,618 crore, the total increase in revenue expenditure is ₹56,438 crore. This shows that the government is more concerned with closing the deficit than passing the benefit of the windfall to the people. This deficit figure is based on receipt projections which can also go awry. In that case, it may be politically difficult for the government to rein in the deficit and stick to its political promises simultaneously.

The expectation of the government regarding an increase in State taxes amounting to ₹18,933 crore seems difficult to attain. This is because according to the Medium Term Fiscal Policy Statement of the government, the Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) of West Bengal is projected to rise from ₹19,90,896 crore in 2025-26 to ₹21,48,244 crore in 2026-27. This entails a nominal growth rate of only 7.9%. In the year 2025-26, the growth rate of nominal GSDP in Bengal was 9.85%. In other words, the government is projecting a 2 percentage points drop in the nominal GSDP growth of the State but assuming an

increase in tax collections of around ₹19,000 crore. Even with 9.85% nominal GSDP growth in the State in 2025-26, the increase in State's tax collection was around ₹13,744 crore as compared with 2024-25. The projected increase in tax collection appears difficult to achieve since the government has not announced any major policy to raise taxes or improve tax compliance. The government may be relying on closing the tax leakage due to corruption. Whatever may be the case, a slowdown in GSDP and a huge increase in tax collection is difficult to materialise simultaneously. Given that it has already committed to a reduction in fiscal and revenue deficits, any shortfall in tax revenue will be met by a cut back on expenditure. This can make the government's political promise to various sections of the people difficult to maintain. On the capital expenditure side, the government is proposing to increase the capital expenditure by around ₹15,000 crore as compared with RE 2025-26. The government has announced a number of infrastructure projects, new colleges and universities in the State. The additional capital expenditure is

welcome. However, here too, the government could have spent more if it did not adhere to a policy of cutting back the deficit.

Laxmir Bhandar vs Annapurna Yojana

The Trinamool government's Laxmir Bhandar scheme covered around 2.4 crore women with a monthly transfer of ₹1,500. The BJP had promised to upgrade beneficiaries to the Annapurna Yojana, offering ₹3,000 per month. However, the ₹36,000-crore allocation announced for the scheme would cover only about 1.3 crore women, as announced by the government. The government has not clearly explained the basis for excluding the remaining beneficiaries. It was announced that individuals whose names were removed during the SIR process would not be eligible for benefits under the scheme. In the absence of transparent criteria, crores of women risk losing access to benefits that were promised without such restrictions. However, the number of women who will lose access to the scheme as compared to Laxmi'r Bhandar turns out to be more than a crore. BJP did not announce any targeting of the scheme in their election manifesto.

The government has raised Dearness Allowance by 20%, announced the 7th Pay Commission and promised one lakh new jobs. However, the higher DA will be paid only from October 2026, while DA arrears also remain to be settled. Given these commitments, it is unclear whether the ₹10,000-crore increase in salary and pension allocations will be sufficient.

The government has sought to balance fiscal prudence with its promises of expanded welfare and higher pay for employees. Its strategy relies on higher central transfers and a projected sharp rise in tax collections. If these projections fail to materialise, both its fiscal targets and political commitments could come under pressure. The coming year will test how successfully it can reconcile political promises with fiscal realities.

The author is Professor of Economics, Presidency University, Kolkata.

THE GIST

The first Budget of the BJP government has tried to accommodate these pre-poll promises of the party, while simultaneously trying to reduce the fiscal deficit.

The expectation of the government regarding an increase in State taxes amounting to ₹18,933 crore seems difficult to attain.

On the capital expenditure side, the government is proposing to increase the capital expenditure by around ₹15,000 crore as compared with RE 2025-26

Why is the chargesheet in the Sarla Bhat case a milestone?

The killing of the 27-year-old was among the first targeted attacks on Kashmiri Pandits after the 1989 insurgency; the filing of the chargesheet is seen by her family and the entire community as a step towards justice

Peerzada Ashiq

The story so far:

After a gap of 36 years, the J&K Police's special cell State Investigation Agency (SIA) filed a chargesheet in the killing of Kashmiri Pandit Sarla Bhat, who worked as a nurse at Srinagar's Sher-i-Kashmir Institute of Medical Sciences (SKIMS). The chargesheet named Jammu Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF) chief Yasin Malik among five accused, only two of whom are alive.

The SIA, which started re-investigation in 2020, decided to initiate proclamation proceedings against the absconding terrorist, Khurshid Ahmad Chalkoo, "the man who pulled the trigger".

He is believed to have exfiltrated to Pakistan Occupied Kashmir (POK). Meanwhile, the SIA chargesheet does not

mention any rape.

What is the significance of this case?

The killing of the 27-year-old nurse was among the first cases of targeted killing of Kashmiri Pandits in the valley following the armed insurrection in 1989. According to official listing, the first such killing took place on September 14, 1989 of Pandit Tika Lal Taploo, an advocate and senior BJP leader and then Pandit Neelkanth Ganjoo, a former judge who had sentenced JKLF founder Maqbool Bhat to death in a murder case.

These targeted killings eventually led to mass migration of Kashmiri Pandits outside Kashmir valley. The SIA said Sarla Bhat was abducted from the vicinity of SKIMS on April 18, 1990, subjected to brutal torture and physical assault, and horrendously killed by automatic rifle fire at Omer Colony, Malbagh, Srinagar. The

filing of the chargesheet is seen by the family and the entire Pandit community as a step towards justice. The magnitude of the migration, the militant violence triggered, can be gauged from the fact that over 60,452 Pandits registered themselves as migrants by 2014, as the community was displaced to different parts of the country, including Jammu.

Why the delay?

Kashmir witnessed targeted killings of both Muslims, mostly affiliated to the National Conference (NC), and Pandits in the 1990s as hundreds of youths joined militant groups and attacked security forces.

Violence by the JKLF declined after Yasin Malik announced a unilateral ceasefire in 1994. An unwritten understanding with the Union government meant that cases against him

were largely not pursued, with a Terrorist and Disruptive Activities Prevention Act (TADA) court in 2009 keeping proceedings in abeyance in key cases, including the Rawalpura killings and the 1989 kidnapping of Mufti Mohammad Sayeed's daughter. Reopening the Sarla Bhat case, the SIA said the investigation had stalled due to the climate of fear and intimidation during the peak years of militancy, which prevented witnesses from coming forward. It described the case as a symbol of one of Kashmir's darkest chapters of terrorism.

What does it mean for Yasin Malik?

The 59-year-old separatist is currently in the Tihar Jail. He faces sentence on two counts of life imprisonment and five 10-year prison sentences in a terror funding case in 2022. However, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) has sought the death penalty in the case. Besides, Malik also faces fresh trials in two other major cases, including the kidnapping and the Indian Air Force attack. His outfit was also banned in 2019 under provisions of Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA).

The JKLF has distanced itself from the murder of Bhat. According to the banned JKLF, Malik on April 8, 1990, just 10 days before the gruesome murder of Bhat, jumped from a five-storey building in Narwara, Srinagar, to evade his arrest

during a BSF raid.

The JKLF claimed that Malik suffered a head injury, which caused his facial paralysis, in the incident.

It claimed that the organisation had launched its own investigations into the killing "but could not carry it forward due to the continued raids by security forces on JKLF leadership". The fact remains that it will be the third major case of terror from the 1990s against Malik and he could face the death penalty if the charges are proven in the court.

Why is it tipped as a landmark development by police?

The police's SIA termed the chargesheet as a landmark development and a defining moment in J&K's fight against terrorism. The 737-page chargesheet was compiled after an "exhaustive investigation, bringing together a formidable body of oral, documentary, forensic, ballistic, medical and electronic evidence accumulated over decades and meticulously analysed".

The SIA says the chargesheet marks a historic milestone in the pursuit of justice for victims of terrorism and stands as one of the most significant breakthroughs in the investigation of legacy terror crimes in Jammu and Kashmir. The chargesheet, the SIA said, sends a powerful and unequivocal message that time can never become a shield for terrorism.

CM YK A IN-X

New, inexpensive Chinese AI model is catching up with OpenAI



Lurking competition: OpenAI and Anthropic logos are seen in this illustration. REUTERS

Reuters
BEIJING/BENGALURU

Since DeepSeek shocked markets early last year with its cheap but powerful AI model, global consumers have been faced with a choice: Chinese offerings with lower prices and less capability or OpenAI or Anthropic, which have poured billions into development.

A model called GLM-5.2, launched last month by Beijing-based startup Z.ai, may finally be closing that gap in terms of Western interest.

Rival U.S. offerings

GLM-5.2 has Silicon Valley buzzing with its coding and agent capabilities, or the ability to execute complex tasks with minimal prompting, that almost rival leading U.S. offerings at a fraction of the cost, in what some experts are calling a “mini DeepSeek moment.”

It has quickly climbed the usage charts on third-party AI developer platforms like OpenRouter, where it now ranks above Anthropic’s models, while executives from cloud data platform Snowflake’s CEO Sridhar Ramaswamy to venture capitalist Marc Andreessen have lauded its abilities.

“We now have a Chinese open-weight model that is as good as the currently available models from OpenAI and Anthropic,” said David Sacks, U.S. President Donald Trump’s former AI czar, last week before Washington lifted curbs on Anthropic’s Fable and Mythos models on Tuesday.

Those capabilities have put Z.ai’s GLM-5.2 model at the heart of a growing debate about whether China is finally catching up to the U.S. in the AI race, as technology executives warn that Washington’s unpredictable regulation of the industry risks hampering its lead in the frontier technology.

“It is just a tick below Opus 4.8 (from Anthropic) and right up there with GPT 5.5 (from OpenAI),” Sacks said of GLM-5.2 on the All-In podcast, adding that “we cannot afford to do things that slow our companies down.”

U.S. curbs fuel demand

The Anthropic curbs and the delayed public rollout of OpenAI’s latest GPT-5.6 model have fuelled global demand for the Chinese model, some experts said.

“The international developer community is increasingly aware that relying solely on proprietary, U.S.-based API models carries significant risk,” said Brian Tse, founder and CEO of Concordia AI, a Beijing-based consultancy focused on AI safety.

GLM-5.2’s positive global reception also suggests increased interest in cheaper open-source development because businesses are getting stung by the rising and often unpredictable costs of using AI to complete tasks, as closed-source agentic AI tools consume more tokens, the units used to measure AI usage.

Z.ai, also known as Zhipu AI, declined to comment. Anthropic and OpenAI did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

GLM-5.2 currently holds fifth place on Artificial Analysis’ large language model (LLM) intelligence leader board, which ranks performance across a range of benchmarks designed to measure overall capability, including reasoning and coding skills. And it is in the second spot on Code Arena’s front-end coding rankings, measuring how well models generate websites and front-end applications, while operating at roughly a sixth of the cost of closed U.S. frontier models like Claude and the GPT series.

Z.ai has not disclosed how much it spent to develop GLM-5.2.

In a reply to Elon Musk on X last month, Z.ai founder Tang Jie said that the Chinese startup could produce a model on par with Anthropic’s Fable before the first quarter of next year.

“The shift GLM-5.2 brings is that the open-source model has become a plug-and-play, out-of-the-box product,” said Tiezhen Wang, former APAC lead at Hugging Face, a startup that serves as a hub for developers tinkering with open-source models.

“You just deploy the model and without doing any complex fine-tuning systems, it is in a highly usable, ready-to-use state. This drastically lowers the barrier to entry for open-source adoption.”

President Donald Trump’s biofuel goals hit reality as U.S. plants lag

U.S. biodiesel producers operated about 77% capacity in May, below the EPA’s 90% assumption for mandates; May generated 736 mn biomass-based diesel RINs versus roughly 915 million needed monthly; AFPM has sued and urged lawmakers to reconsider the 2026 biofuel mandates

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

President Donald Trump’s effort to boost production of bio-based diesel and deliver on promises to farmers and rural communities is colliding with a market reality: U.S. plants are not keeping up with his targets. The production gap carries political and economic risks.

A sustained shortfall could send renewable fuel credit prices sharply higher and force the Trump administration to invoke a rarely used provision allowing it to lower the mandates it previously set to reflect market conditions.

Such an unusual retreat would upset farmers and biofuel producers who fought for larger quotas and who make up an important political constituency heading in to mid-term elections.

The Environmental Protection Agency, which administers U.S. biofuel policy, set record biofuel blending targets for 2026 under the Renewable Fuel Standard, a law that requires refiners to blend prescribed volumes of ethanol and biodiesel into the fuel supply or buy compliance credits known as RINs.

For 2026, oil refiners



In focus: The Front Range Energy ethanol plant at Windsor, Colorado, U.S. REUTERS

must generate or purchase 8.86 billion RINs, the equivalent of blending a record 5.4 billion gallons of biodiesel and renewable diesel – a target that is over 60% higher than 2025 levels. Trump has touted the moves as a sign of his support for farmers. The EPA mandate assumes producers can run at about 90% of capacity over the course of the year. Instead, operating rates at U.S. biodiesel plants were just under 77% in May, while renewable diesel facilities were at 78%, according to Zander Capozzola, principal consultant at Argus Media. Some production is also committed to export contracts, where prices have been stronger because of supply disruptions tied to the Iran war. Those gallons



Sustained shortfall could send renewable fuel credit prices sharply higher and force the Trump administration to invoke a rarely used provision allowing it to lower the mandates

do not generate credits toward EPA mandates. Refiners generated 736 million RINs in May, according to EPA data, well below the roughly 915 million needed each month to stay on pace, said Scott Irwin, an agricultural economist at the University of Illinois.

He estimates production through the first four months of 2026 lagged required levels by 1.41 billion

RINs, a gap that would require output to exceed the industry’s highest monthly production by more than 20% for the remainder of the year.

Run at highest pace

“The mandates effectively require biodiesel plants to run at their highest sustained pace on record and renewable diesel plants to operate well beyond any pace they’ve ever achieved,” Irwin said.

“There is no way the industry is going to meet its targets at the rate they are going,” said Paul Niznik, director of energy at Washington, D.C.-based Capstone LLC, which advises refineries, fuel marketers and hedge fund clients.

“The shortfall is causing widespread concern

Persistent plans mulls AI engineering edge by buying German firm Nagarro in ₹11,820 cr. deal

EXPLAINER

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

On early Saturday morning Pune-based mid-sized company Persistent Systems Ltd. announced entering into an agreement to acquire Nagarro, a Munich, German-headquartered digital engineering company, through a voluntary public takeover offer valuing that company at €1.1 billion (₹11,820 crore).

The acquisition will be done by Persistent Systems and its wholly owned direct subsidiary Galaxy Germany Holding SE.

Once completed, the deal would create one of the world’s largest AI-led digital engineering companies with almost \$2.9 billion in annual revenue and more than 46,000 employees across more than 40 countries.

What it is about?

Persistent Systems has signed a Business Combination Agreement (BCA) with Nagarro and will offer €81 per Nagarro share in cash to all shareholders which represents about a 140% premium over Nagarro’s closing share price before the announcement.

Persistent wants to buy all outstanding shares of Nagarro and delist the company from the stock exchange of Germany.

Persistent has also entered into a fully binding share purchase agreement with Lantano Beteiligung GmbH, the investment vehicle of the largest shareholder of Nagarro, under which Lantano has agreed to sell its entire approximately 21% stake in Nagarro (excluding treasury



Win-win deal: Customers can avail end-to-end digital transformation from strategy to execution.

shares) to the bidder at the offer price.

Why this deal?

The acquisition is driven by one major theme which is building a global AI powerhouse.

Both companies believe the next generation of IT services will revolve around Artificial Intelligence, Digital Engineering, Cloud, Enterprise Modernization, ERP and Customer Experience (CX).

Rather than building these capabilities over many years, the merger allows Persistent to combine strengths immediately.

The transaction is expected to be cash EPS accretive for Persistent shareholders in the first year of the transaction. Persistent will fund the transaction with committed financing from Barclays.

Deal synergies

While Persistent has strong capabilities in AI-led software engineering, cloud and platform engineering also has sizeable business in North America with banking and healthcare clients, Nagarro has

Telecommunications.

Why deal is crucial

Stronger AI capabilities: The combined entity will have more AI engineers, large AI platforms, better enterprise AI solutions, greater ability to deliver large AI transformation projects.

Geographic balance

Persistent has traditionally been stronger in North America. Now, Nagarro brings deep European customer relationships, four of Europe’s top five automotive manufacturers as clients, local delivery teams across Europe. This will significantly boost Persistent’s Europe presence.

Larger customer base

The combined entity will have over 350 major enterprise customers, top global banks, leading healthcare companies, major automotive manufacturers and technology companies.

This would create more opportunities to cross-sell services.

What about Nagarro?

If shareholders approve the offer it will become part of Persistent which plans to delist Nagarro from the Frankfurt Stock Exchange. Nagarro’s management and culture are expected to be retained.

Persistent says it does not intend to implement a domination and profit transfer agreement (DPLTA) for at least two years after closing of the deal.

What about staff?

According to Persistent the deal is focused on growth rather than cost-cutting. It has said employees can expect larger international

across the industry and what the policy reaction might be.”

He added that market participants do not expect the EPA to intervene, despite having the authority to grant a waiver, and instead could consider measures such as lowering 2028 obligations by changing how imported volumes are counted toward obligations.

Policy uncertainty

Production was held back for months as biodiesel and renewable diesel producers waited for the Trump administration to finalise guidance for the federal 45Z clean fuel production tax credit.

The guidance, released in recent weeks, removed some land-use restrictions and increased incentives for soy-based renewable diesel, changes the industry had sought for a year.

The changes provide greater certainty to expand production and sign feed stock contracts with farmers, said Jeramie Weller, general manager of Minnesota Soybean Processors, a biodiesel producer. Though the changes will likely hike output, it remains unclear whether they came soon enough to offset earlier production losses.

A surge in petroleum prices tied to the Iran conflict also dampened growth in biodiesel pro-

duction, as supply disruptions boosted margins for conventional fuels, giving refiners greater incentive to maximise petroleum-based output rather than increase renewable fuel production.

Shrinking credit market

Lower-than-expected production is also depleting a cushion that has historically helped the market absorb shortfalls.

The so-called RIN bank – a stockpile of unused credits refiners can draw on to meet mandates – has been steadily depleted this year as production falls short and demand remains high. If the trend continues, analysts warn the buffer could be exhausted by the end of 2026, boosting prices for the credits. RIN prices have already surged to record highs, raising compliance costs for smaller refiners that rely on buying credits rather than blending fuel themselves. The tightening outlook has intensified lobbying pressure in Washington. The nation’s largest refining trade group, the American Fuel and Petrochemical Manufacturers, has been meeting with lawmakers on Capitol Hill to push the administration to reconsider the 2026 bio-fuel mandates. It has also filed lawsuit against the EPA. “Americans will pay billions more than they should if the RFS isn’t right-sized,” AFPM said.

DOHA

‘Positive progress’ in U.S.-Iran indirect talks: Qatar spokesperson



U.S. and Iran negotiators made “positive progress” during indirect talks in Doha, with the next round expected after the late Iranian Supreme Leader’s funeral, Qatar’s Foreign Ministry spokesperson Majed Al Ansari said on X. “The parties agreed to continue the discussions over the coming period,” he added. AFP

BERLIN

German ruling coalition agrees on major reform package, says Merz



Germany’s ruling coalition has agreed on sweeping tax, labour and pension reforms, Chancellor Friedrich Merz said on Thursday, a breakthrough aimed at reviving the struggling economy and countering the rise of the far right. “We are working to increase the flexibility of our businesses,” Mr. Merz told a Berlin press meet. AFP

BANGKOK

Thailand denies claim that Macron knelt before king during state visit



Thailand’s Foreign Ministry denied on Thursday that French President Emmanuel Macron knelt before the country’s king during his state visit to Paris this week, after an AI-generated picture circulated online. King Maha Vajiralongkorn’s trip was the first official visit by a Thai monarch to France since 1960. AFP

BERLIN

NATO plans to replace AWACS with Saab GlobalEye jets, say sources



NATO plans to replace its ageing fleet of AWACS aircraft with GlobalEye surveillance planes from Sweden’s Saab, four sources said, a move that could test uneasy relations with U.S. President Donald Trump. They said NATO will announce the GlobalEye plans during a meeting of its members in Ankara on July 7 and 8. REUTERS

Russian attack kills 21 in Kyiv as Ukraine hits Moscow’s oil sector

Moscow says strikes were retaliation for Ukrainian attacks on oil facilities, adding that the bombardment was ‘exclusively against military or military-linked targets’; Kyiv’s long-range strikes have triggered the worst fuel crisis in Crimea since 2014

Associated Press
KYIV

Russia hammered Kyiv in an 11-hour drone and missile attack overnight into Thursday morning, killing at least 21 civilians in the city and injuring more than 90 others in what Moscow said was retaliation for Ukrainian strikes on Russian oil facilities.

Loud explosions shook the Ukrainian capital, where more than 50,000 people sheltered in subway stations after authorities issued air raid warnings, the Kyiv Metro said. Emergency crews dug through the rubble of collapsed and



People look at the site of a Russian missile strike that hit a residential building in Kyiv, Ukraine, on Thursday. AP

charred apartment buildings all day in search of victims.

Russia’s Defence Ministry said in a statement that the bombardment was in

response to Ukraine’s recent barrage of long-range strikes, which have caused severe fuel shortages and put pressure on President Vladimir Putin.

Ukraine’s frequent attacks inside Russia – described by President Volodymyr Zelenskyy as a 40-day blitz – have especially targeted oil refineries, causing a fuel crisis that has frustrated Russians already feeling the war’s economic toll.

More than four years after Moscow’s full-scale invasion of its neighbour, Ukraine’s technological advances in drone engineering have in recent months given it an edge, analysts and Western officials say. Its strikes on supply routes behind the front line have robbed the Russian army of momentum on the battlefield and

made its progress slow and costly, they say.

Kyiv’s forces have especially targeted supplies to Crimea, triggering the worst fuel crisis on the Black Sea peninsula since it was illegally annexed by Russia in 2014 and delivering a blow to the Kremlin’s narrative that Moscow is winning the war.

Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said it was a “night of horror” in the capital, which had a pre-war population of roughly 3 million people.

The bombardment was “exclusively against military or military-linked targets,” Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said.

‘Ukrainian state ordered Nord Stream sabotage’

Agence France-Presse
BERLIN

German prosecutors said on Thursday that the Ukrainian state ordered a 2022 bomb attack on the Nord Stream gas pipelines, complicating relations between Kyiv and its key military backer Berlin.

The sabotage, never claimed by any actor, destroyed three of the four Baltic seafloor pipelines of the major energy link from Russia to Germany and released huge amounts of methane into the atmosphere.

The Ukrainian government has always denied ordering the destruction of the pipelines, which had in earlier times allowed Russia to earn billions through gas sales to Germany and beyond.



Gas leak at the Nord Stream 2 pipeline off the Danish Baltic island of Bornholm, south of Dueodde in 2022. AFP

News broke on Wednesday that German prosecutors had now levelled charges against the Ukrainian suspect Serhii Kuznetsov, who is alleged to have led a team of divers in the high-stakes operation.

He was arrested while on holiday in Italy last summer and extradited to Germany in November.

In a statement on Thursday detailing the charges, including the alleged war crime of targeting civilian infrastructure, German prosecutors said that he was “an officer in the Ukrainian army” and that he and other military personnel had acted “on the orders of state authorities in Ukraine”.

Iran tells tankers to use approved routes in Strait of Hormuz

Associated Press
DUBAI

Iran’s joint military command warned on Thursday that all oil tankers moving through the Strait of Hormuz must use its approved routes or face a “forceful response,” again ratcheting up tensions over a waterway crucial for international energy supplies.

The statement from the Khatam al-Anbiya military command, reported by Iranian state television, comes after both U.S. and Iranian diplomats met with mediators on Wednesday in Qatar.

It wasn’t immediately clear what sparked the threat from Iran. However,

the U.S. military’s Central Command had put out a statement about having a meeting with officials from West Asia nations in Bahrain that said “leaders underscored their shared commitment to the free flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz”. That appears to have been the phrase to anger Iran.

“Any failure to comply, deviation from the designated route, or disregard for the navigation protocols of the Islamic Republic of Iran in the Strait of Hormuz will be met with an immediate and forceful response from the armed forces, endangering the security of the violating vessels,” the statement said.

Unspoken conflict



Bold reflection: Chinese artist Ai Weiwei poses with one of his new works entitled ‘History of Bombs’, during a photocall to promote his forthcoming exhibition ‘Ai Weiwei: Button Up!’, at the Aviva Studios in Manchester, northern England, on Wednesday. AFP

Pakistan PM Sharif to visit Iran to attend Khamenei’s funeral

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and his top Ministers will visit Iran on Friday to participate in the funeral of late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was assassinated in U.S.-Israeli strikes in February, the Foreign Office announced on Thursday.

“The Prime Minister will convey condolences on behalf of the people and government of Pakistan to the Iranian leadership and the bereaved families while reaffirming solidarity with the brotherly nation in their hour of profound grief,” Foreign Office



Shehbaz Sharif

spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said.

Deputy PM and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, Cabinet members and senior officials will accompany the premier on his visit. From Tehran, PM Sharif would travel to Turkey at the invitation of President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, he said.

Vatican excommunicates schismatic bishops and priests, warns followers

Agence France-Presse
VATICAN CITY

The Vatican excommunicated six bishops from the ultraconservative Society of St Pius X on Thursday, while warning that any lay believers who “formally adhere” to the breakaway Catholic group would suffer the same fate.

The Vatican decree comes a day after the traditionalist group consecrated four new bishops, openly defying a plea from Pope Leo XIV to desist and exacerbating a rift dating from 1988 when the group earlier consecrated four bishops.

Calling the ceremony “an act of schismatic nature,” the Vatican’s power-



Newly consecrated bishops pray at the end of their consecration ceremony in Econe, Switzerland, on Wednesday. AP

ful Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith – which is charged with defending Catholic doctrine – explained in an accompanying note that the consecrations were “in open violation of canon law” and the excommunicated bishops “schismatics”.

For the Holy See, consecrating bishops without the approval of the Pope, the head of the Catholic Church ruling over some 1.4 billion faithful, is a direct act of insubordination, leading to the automatic excommunication of the bishops involved.

The excommunication covers the newly-ordained bishops – two French, an American and a Swiss – and the two existing bishops who presided over the ceremony in Econe in southwest Switzerland.

The rite, attended by thousands of worshippers from around the world, began with the society’s secretary general, Foucault Leroux, stating that “any penalties and censures... are null and void”.

The Society of Saint Pius X, which has around 600,000 followers around the world, comprises fundamentalist Catholics who strongly oppose the liberal reforms imposed by the Vatican II Council in the 1960s.

Nine killed and 20 injured as explosive device goes off at cafe in Syria’s capital

Associated Press
DAMASCUS

An explosive device was detonated on Thursday in a cafe in the Syrian capital of Damascus, killing at least nine persons, Syria’s Health Ministry said.

The explosion near the main courthouse complex left 20 others wounded, the Ministry said as reported by Syria’s state-run *Al-Ikhabariya* network.

No group immediately claimed responsibility. Security forces rushed to the cafe and cordoned off the area as they investigate the attack.

The Interior Ministry is set to announce its initial findings soon, said Damascus Governor Maher Idlibi.



Syrian security inspects the site after an explosive device detonated in a cafe in Damascus, Syria, on Thursday. AP

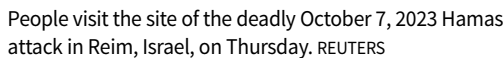
Mr. Idlibi said the device appeared “primitive” and vowed that the perpetrators will be held to account.

A video circulating on social media showed several wounded people lying on the ground, with police

officers nearby. Ambulances later rushed to the scene treating people on site and taking the more severely wounded to hospitals in the Syrian capital. The cafe was frequented by lawyers who worked in the neighbourhood.

Since overthrowing the Assad dynasty and taking power in a lightning insurgency in December 2024, Syria’s new rulers have cracked down on militants from the extremist Islamic State group in an attempt to thwart attacks in and around the capital.

Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa, since coming to power, has vowed to protect Syrians and reasserted the government’s full authority across the vast majority of the country, wresting control back from extremist groups or Kurdish-led forces. However, several incidents such as suicide bombing in a Church in July 2025 have raised concerns among many Syrians.



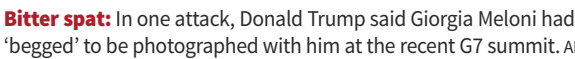
Agence France Presse
JERUSALEM

According to polls, a large number of Israelis across the political spectrum support the establishment of a body to determine who is responsible for the failure to prevent the deadliest-ever attack on Israel. Mr. Netanyahu's government, however, has long refused to establish such a panel, the likes of which Israel has commonly set up in the past to probe major state-level failings.

Associated Press
ROME

This newfound European unity could be tested

ers of Germany, France, Britain and Poland. And she met the next day with French President Emmanuel Macron in southern



In Germany, leaders of the far-right Alternative for Germany party have criticised the U.S. military campaign against Iran. The co-

These dynamics are playing out beyond the European Union, from the Arctic Ocean to the Balkans. When Mr. Trump threatened to take Greenland by force, protests erupted in its capital, Nu-

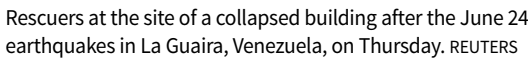
Though Ms. Meloni remains closely aligned with Mr. Trump on issues like immigration and security, she has long diverged from him on Ukraine. Her steadfast support for Kyiv made her more palatable for European leaders and has been a key factor in forging a more united European front toward the U.S. Dur-

Voters across Europe could hold their own politicians accountable for the actions of an American President beyond their control, said Castellani, the political analyst. "At a certain point, when voters see the price of gasoline rising because of a war perceived as distant, they ask Meloni for the bill, not Trump."

Rift over resort: Police use a water cannon during a protest against a planned luxury resort backed by a company linked to U.S. President Donald Trump's son-in-law, Jared Kushner, on an ecologically sensitive stretch of the Adriatic coast, in Tirana, Albania, on Thursday. REUTERS

Agence France Presse
LA GUAIRA

Tens of thousands of people remain unaccounted for. The majority of collapsed buildings in the hardest-hit city of La Guaira, just north of Caracas, have been marked with the let-



"Time isn't wasted in a place where there is no expectation of recovering people alive," said Javier Rodes, the coordinator of a Spanish rescue team whose sniffer dog Nala

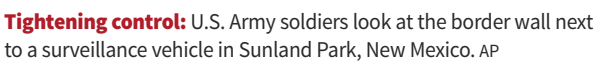
There have been miracle survivors, such as a three-year-old boy found alive Tuesday, six days after Venezuela's most powerful quake in over a century. A 44-year-old security guard was dug out alive on Thursday morning. But ex-

Associated Press
PHOENIX

The wall is under heavy scrutiny for the billions of dollars being dedicated to it when border crossings are at their lowest in decades. Critics say the U.S. is militarising the border as it increasingly deploys so-

"It's a smart wall. It's not just a barrier," Customs and Border Protection Commissioner Rodney Scott said during recent congressional testimony. "It maximises the use of

Flush with \$46 billion to finish the wall after an infusion by Congress for immigration enforcement, CBP is inking tens of billions of



Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin said recently that a preliminary part of the wall will be finished by "this time next year." Mr. Scott said his agency is putting up 6 miles (10 kilometres) of

wall a week. Hundreds of miles had already been built before Mr. Trump returned to office. As of mid-June 2026, CBP has erected another 74 miles (119 kilometres) and aims to build hundreds more. There is no wall planned for roughly 535 miles (861 kilometres) of the roughly 2,000-mile-long (3,200-kilometre) border.

Technology is playing a greater role in the Trump administration's effort to make illegal crossings along the border more difficult, part of a broader transformation of CBP in the years since September

Garza, the group's policy counsel, warned that surveillance technology infringes on the privacy rights of border residents and that locals have found ground sensors used to detect smuggler or migrant traffic placed on their property without their con-

Dave Maass, director of investigations for the Electronic Frontier Foundation, a nonprofit that focuses on civil liberties related to digital technology, said the technology has made the border area “a hostile environment” for locals and would-be migrants.

INBRIEF



Norris says Verstappen’s move to McLaren ‘not serious’

Lando Norris says reports that Max Verstappen has considered a move to McLaren are “a cool thing” to hear but “not a serious thing” as speculation swirls in Formula One about a switch which could create a line-up of two champions. “It’s good that a four-time World champion wants to come on board and wants to potentially join the team. I don’t know how much of it’s true and if there’s an opportunity for me to drive with other people, it’s something I’ve always looked forward to. But it’s not a serious thing for now”.

India to play two-Test series in Sri Lanka next month

India will play two Tests against Sri Lanka in Galle (from August 15) and SSC Colombo (from August 23), SLC announced on Thursday. The series is part of the World Test Championship. India, which has made two finals but never won the WTC title, is currently fifth in the standings, while Sri Lanka is sixth. The last time India toured Sri Lanka for a Test series was in 2017 when it had won 3-0.



Man City signs Anderson in record club transfer

Elliot Anderson joined Manchester City from Nottingham Forest on Thursday, in a deal reported to be the most expensive transfer for a British player. The clubs did not disclose financial details, but British media reports said the deal is worth up to £116 million, surpassing the £105 million Arsenal paid West Ham United for Declan Rice.

BAI introduces 3x15 scoring system in domestic circuit

The high-intensity 3x15 format will take effect across domestic rankings, zonals and National championships from this month onwards with the Badminton Association of India (BAI) implementing the new BWF scoring system across the domestic circuit to ensure a seamless transition for the Indian shuttlers. Under the revised format, matches will continue to be played as best-of-three games under rally-point scoring, but each game will now be played to 15 points instead of 21. A two-point lead remains mandatory from 14-all, with games capped at 21 points, where the next point becomes decisive at 20-all.

WTA Finals moved from Riyadh to Indian Wells

The WTA Finals, the traditional season-ender for women’s tennis, has been moved from Riyadh to Indian Wells this year, the women’s tour announced in a statement on Wednesday. The event, which brings together the eight best players of the year at the end of the season in November in both singles and doubles, had been staged since 2024 in the Saudi capital and was supposed to remain there for at least three years. The final year has been terminated by mutual consent. Elena Rybakina won the 2025 event, beating Aryna Sabalenka in the final.



West Ham’s Mateus Fernandes joins Spurs

West Ham’s midfielder Mateus Fernandes has joined Spurs after the Hammers’s relegation from PL, the clubs announced on Thursday. The 21-year-old’s move across the capital city is worth a reported club record fee of £85 million.

Rain mars opener after India sets a target of 190

Quick-fire fifties by Abhishek and skipper Shreyas help the Men in Blue recover from a poor start after opting to bat; Dube chips in with a cameo; pacer Mahmood impresses for England



No holding back: Abhishek counter-attacked after Samson and Kishan fell early. AFP

INDIA IN ENGLAND
Agence France-Presse
CHESTER-LE-STREET (UK)

Teenage batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi was once more denied an India debut before rain saw the first Twenty20 International against England abandoned after the tourist’s innings here on Wednesday. Spectators at Durham’s headquarters were given a tantalising glimpse of the 15-year-old prodigy as he warmed up on the outfield before play started. But for the third match in a row this tour, following T20 world champion India’s shock 2-0 series loss to Ireland in Belfast, Sooryavanshi was not picked in the playing XI. It looked like India might regret its decision to do without Sooryavanshi when it slumped to six for two after winning the toss. But the Men in Blue recovered to post a total of 189 for seven, compiled through steady rainfall. Heavier rain came dur-

ing the interval, bringing the covers on to the ground, with the match called off at 19.15 GMT. India lost Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan in the second over. Samson was superbly caught by a leaping Tom Banton off Saqib Mahmood, while Kishan was run out in a mix-up with Abhishek Sharma. Abhishek made amends with a dynamic 59 from 24 balls – one Mahmood over went for 21, including two pulled sixes – before he was trapped in front by a Sam Curran slower one. Captain Shreyas Iyer and Shivam Dube added late impetus, with 64 runs scored off the final six overs. Shreyas struck 68 from 47 balls and Dube 42 not out off 21 before rain cut short the first of a five-match campaign. The series now moves on to Old Trafford for the second T20I on Saturday. The scores: India 189/7 in 20 overs (Abhishek 59, Shreyas 68, Dube 42 n.o., Mahmood 3/33) vs England. Toss: India.



Stellar show: Cape Verde enters the knockouts unbeaten. REUTERS

No stars, no problem for Cape Verde

FIFA WORLD CUP
R.K. Arjun

The script was written long ago – small island nation, eliminated at the group stage, goes home with a good story. But, Cape Verde has not read it. Three games in at the 2026 World Cup, it is unbeaten, through to the knockouts, and nobody is quite sure what to expect from the African nation. Cape Verde became a FIFA member in 1986. After failing to qualify for the 2002 extravaganza, the country made steady progress. Cape Verde attained its first AFCON qualification in 2013 and came close to sealing a World Cup berth in 2022, only to fall short at the final hurdle. Four years later, it went one better – topping its CAF group ahead of Cameroon to book its tickets for the North American showcase. Cape Verde’s first test was against a Spanish side that had dismantled defences on the way to the EURO 2024 title. The Sharks held the Spaniards to a goalless draw through an exemplary display from their 40-year-old goalkeeper Vozinha. They then came from behind to hold Uruguay 2-2. Saudi Arabia, too, could not find a way past the Cape Verde defence. It now has a date with Lionel Messi’s Argentina in the round of 32. A year ago, that sentence would have read as fiction. However, Bubista’s men have spent the last three weeks making the football world question everything it thought it knew. Why stop now?

Arachchige’s unbeaten 83 guides SL-A to 288 for five

Press Trust of India
GALLE

Medium-pacer Yash Thakur and off-spinner Saransh Jain took two wickets apiece but Sri Lanka-A rode on skipper Sahan Arachchige’s unbeaten 83 to reach 288 for five on the opening day of the second ‘Test’ against India-A here on Thursday. Arachchige, whose 148-ball innings had nine fours and a six, enjoyed a 99-run stand for the fifth wicket with wicketkeeper Anjala Bandara (42). For the visiting side, lanky speedster Gurnoor Brar was also among the wickets while leg-spinner Zeeshan Ansari, playing his first red-ball game after a gap of six years, gave away 64 off his 16 wicketless overs. Ansari was the biggest disappointment of the day. The scores: Sri Lanka-A 288/5 in 85 overs (Arachchige 83 batting, Fernando 44, Anjala Bandara 42, Saransh 2/77, Yash 2/32) vs. India-A.

Praggnanandhaa in joint second spot



Mind games: Praggnanandhaa and Gukesh played out a hard-fought draw. FLICKR/GRANDCHESSTOUR

CHESS
Press Trust of India
ZAGREB

Grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa began his campaign in the Zagreb leg of the Grand Chess Tour with a victory over top seed Vincent Keymer of Germany before drawing his next two games to finish the opening day of the Rapid section in joint second place on Wednesday. Praggnanandhaa held France’s Maxime Vachier-Lagrave and compatriot D. Gukesh to hard-fought

draws to end the day on four points. Alireza Firouzja of France emerged sole leader with five points. The nine rounds of rapid will be followed by an 18-round Blitz marathon and the winner will be decided with cumulative points in both sections. Standings (after round three, Rapid): 1. Alireza Firouzja (Fra, 5); 2-5: Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Fra), R. Praggnanandhaa, Anish Giri (Ned), Vincent Keymer (Ger) 4; 6-7: D. Gukesh, Deac Bogdan-Daniel (Rou) 3; 8. Nodirbek Abdusattorov (Uzb, 2); 9. Jorden van Foreest (Ned, 1); 10. Ivan Saric (Cro, 0).

World Cup offers a chance for the immigrant communities to reunite

Avon Sengupta

For 90 minutes in Philadelphia, Haitians were home again. Outside the Lincoln Financial Field, vendors sold griot and patties from food trucks while Creole floated through the humid afternoon air. Families arrived wrapped in blue and red flags. Children who had never lived in Haiti knew every word of the ‘La Desalinienne’, the national anthem. The team eventually lost to Brazil, but the result almost felt beside the point. For a country that has endured political violence, earthquakes and humanitarian crises, simply returning to the World Cup had become a celebration of survival. Many of those in the stands had travelled not from Port-au-Prince but from Brooklyn, Miami, Boston and Montreal. They carried two homes with them – one that they had left behind and the one they had built in the United States of America. The expanded 48-team World Cup has not just in-



Vociferous support: Ivory Coast fans cheer their team during the round of 32 match against Norway. REUTERS

troduced new footballing nations, but it has reunited immigrant communities scattered across North America. Every match has become a family reunion of sorts, where flags stored away for years have reappeared. Dallas, home to one of the largest and most active West African populations in the US, welcomed the Ivory Coast team with the Abidjan Farot Welcome Party on the eve of its round of 16 clash. “My son has never been to Abidjan or anywhere in Ivory Coast. So, I brought him here so that he could feel to be part of the nation. We are incredibly proud of our team who has connected us in this World Cup,” said N’Guessan, who had travelled from Atlanta with his four-year-old son. Tanya Marie surprised his mother Chilemb Munung with World Cup tickets to see the Democratic Republic of Congo play Portugal at the Houston Stadium. “I can’t even express to myself what I was feeling there, but it was like oh my God,” Chilemb said after the match. For 90 minutes, football has dissolved the distance between where these communities came from and where they live now.

Srikanth retires; Aakarshi and Tanya advance in Canada Open

Press Trust of India
MARKHAM

India’s K. Srikanth retired early from his opening match due to fitness issues even as Tanya Hemnath and Aakarshi Kashyap progressed to the women’s singles second round at the Canada Open Super 300 badminton tournament here. The 33-year-old Srikanth, who finished runner-up at the US Open Super 300 last Sunday, was lagging 10-11 against Paris Olympic bronze medallist Lee Zii Jia of Malaysia in the men’s singles opening round when he decided to throw in the towel after consulting with coach B. Sai Praneeth. Aakarshi saw off Anna Tatránova of France 21-14,

21-12, while Tanya prevailed 21-16, 21-18 over USA’s Disha Gupta. It was otherwise a dismal show for India as seven out of nine shuttlers failed to cross the opening hurdle on Wednesday. Fifth seed Devika Sihag lost 14-21, 15-21 to Taiwan’s Tung Ciou-Tong while Rakshitha Ramraj went down fighting 15-21, 21-14, 21-15 against Canada’s Rachel Chan. Shriyanshi Valishetty lost 9-21, 18-21 against Taiwan’s Huang Ching Pi. Annmol Kharb played out of her skin before going down 6-21, 26-24, 13-21 against home favourite and top seed Michelle Li. In men’s singles, Saneeth Dayanand and Sanakar Subramanian, also fell by the wayside in the open-

ing round. While Saneeth lost 7-21, 11-21 against third seed Yudai Okimoto of Japan, Sanakar’s fight ended with a 21-19, 15-21, 15-21 loss to Korea’s Yoo Tae-bin. The results (first round): Men: Lee Zii Jia bt K. Srikanth 11-10 ret.; Yudai Okimoto bt Saneeth Dayanand 21-7, 21-11; Yoo Tae-bin bt Sanakar Subramanian 19-21, 21-15, 21-15. Doubles: T.A. Lindeman & K. Lee bt Achutaditya Rao Doddavarapu & Arjun Reddy Pochana 21-9, 21-7. Women: Tanya Hemnath bt Disha Gupta 21-16, 21-18; Aakarshi Kashyap bt Anna Tatránova 21-14, 21-12; Tung Ciou-Tong bt Devika Sihag 21-14, 21-15; Rachel Chan bt Rakshitha Ramraj 15-21, 21-14, 21-15; Huang Ching Pi bt Shriyanshi Valishetty 21-9, 21-18; Michelle Li bt Annmol Kharb 21-6, 24-26, 21-13.

‘Asian Games not an exposure tour’

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

The Sports Ministry has categorically said that major events including the Asian and Commonwealth Games are not “exposure tours” and only those who qualify and can deliver performance will be cleared by the government. Sports Minister Manukh Mandaviya on Thursday made it clear that there would be complete transparency in selections but, at the same time, there would be strict scrutiny of entries and travellers would not be included simply to make up the numbers. “Asian Games or Commonwealth Games is not for exposure, it is a platform for athletes who can make the country proud. That is why we have the se-

lection criteria saying only the top six in continental rankings would be considered. Exposure can be gained elsewhere, there is enough time and competition through the years. “The ministry will never stop anyone from that. If federations prepare a training or exposure plan for LA 2028 and submit it to us now, they will have our full support for the next two years. Even individual athletes who wish to train anywhere in the world will be given assistance. But going to Asian Games simply because participation means jobs will not be cleared,” he declared during an interaction. The Indian athletes’ contingent for Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya this year is expected to be capped at 560 and Manda-

viya insisted that while all federations had to follow the ministry guidelines for selections, the ministry had the final word in clearing names. Strict norms “Videography in the presence of a government observer is mandatory. The selected names are then sent to the IOA, who forwards it to Sports Authority of India for vetting. That list then comes to the ministry for final clearance and only those will be allowed,” he added. Ministry sources said that the practice of parents or relatives travelling as part of the official contingent by doubling up as team managers or coaches would not be entertained. “A federation’s list does not constitute the final contingent,” they added.

